

CHAPTER 18: DAY SEVEN

* * *

iPhone Alarm *April 2022*

6:00 AM — “Last day” 6:05 AM — “Get up” 6:10
AM — “Seriously get up”

All three snoozed.

* * *

I set three alarms because I knew I wouldn’t want to wake up. Not because I was tired. Because waking up meant the countdown was real. Fourteen hours until my flight. Fourteen hours of being in the same room as her, breathing the same air, and every breath was a countdown.

She was already awake. I could feel it. The specific stillness of a person who is lying next to you with their eyes open, pretending to sleep because they know that the moment one of you speaks, the day starts, and neither of you wants the day to start because the day ends at the airport.

“I know you’re awake,” I said.

“I know you know.”

“We should get up.”

“No.”

“The flight—”

“No.”

She rolled into me. Face against my chest. Arms around my ribs. Legs tangled with mine in a way that would have been uncomfortable if comfort were the point. Comfort wasn't the point. Contact was the point. Maximum surface area. As much of her skin against as much of mine as physics allowed.

We lay like that for forty-five minutes. Not sleeping. Not talking. Just lying in a bed that had been ours for seven days, in a room that smelled like us — chai and hotel soap and sex and biryani and the jasmine from her hair — and breathing.

Forty-five minutes of breathing next to a woman I wouldn't breathe next to again for who knows how long.

* * *

She cried in the shower.

I heard it through the door. Not sobbing. The quiet kind. The kind where water covers most of the sound but not all of it, and you stand outside the bathroom

door with your hand on the handle and you think about going in but you don't because some grief needs privacy, even from the person causing it.

I packed instead. Packing was mechanical. Shirt, pants, charger, passport. The muscle memory of a man who's been leaving places his whole life. But this time the room fought back. Every surface had evidence of her. A hair tie on the nightstand. Her slippers by the door. The dent in her pillow that still held the shape of her head.

I picked up the hair tie. Small. Black. Elastic. She'd pulled her hair up while cooking last night. The smell of coconut oil was still on it.

I put it in my bag. She'd never ask about it. She had a hundred of them. But I'd have one, and on some Tuesday in Seattle when the silence was too loud, I'd find it in my pocket and remember a room that smelled like chai and jasmine and the worst minibar butter in India.

* * *

Last breakfast.

She ordered dosa. I ordered idli. She stole my chutney. I stole her sambar. The same dance we'd done

every morning for seven days, so practiced now that it felt like choreography.

“Your flight is at 10:15?” she said.

“10:45.”

“So you need to leave by—”

“Don’t.”

“Ari.”

“I know the math. Don’t say it out loud.”

She looked at her dosa. Tore a piece. Dipped it. Chewed. Every movement slow. Deliberately slow. Like she could stretch the morning by stretching each bite.

“Can I ask you something?” she said.

“Anything.”

“In 2019. The first trip. When you left. What did you think about on the plane?”

“You.”

“What specifically?”

“The gulab jamun. The syrup on your chin. The fact that I’d just had the best three days of my life and I was sitting in economy class eating airplane peanuts and trying not to cry.”

“Did you cry?”

“I told myself I had allergies.”

“On a plane.”

“Sudden onset plane allergies.”

She smiled. Not the full smile. The half one. The one that lives in the left corner of her mouth when something is funny and sad at the same time.

“What are you going to think about on the plane this time?” she said.

“The kothu parotta fight.”

She laughed. A real one this time. “That’s what you’ll remember? The fight?”

“That’s what I’ll remember. Because fights mean we’re real. Fights mean this isn’t just two people escaping. Fights mean I know how you take your chai and you know I snore and we can disagree about parotta and still sit across from each other the next morning stealing each other’s chutney.”

“You’re going to make me cry.”

“You already cried. In the shower. I heard you.”

“I wasn’t crying. I was singing.”

“That was singing?”

“I’m not a good singer.”

“Meera. That was the worst singing I’ve ever heard. And I do TikTok Lives.”

She threw a piece of dosa at me. It hit my cheek. Chutney and all.

* * *

Uber to the Airport *April 2022*

The ride was thirty-two minutes. We held hands the entire time. Not laced fingers. Not casual touching. The desperate grip of two people holding on to something they can't keep. Her palm was sweating. Mine was sweating. India is hot and goodbyes are hotter.

The driver had the radio on. Some Tamil love song from the '90s. Because the universe is a DJ who reads the room and decides to make it worse.

She leaned into me. Her head on my shoulder. The same position from the auto-rickshaw after the parotta fight. But this time the silence wasn't comfortable. This time the silence was full. Packed with everything we couldn't say because saying it would break both of us and we needed to hold together for thirty-two more minutes.

At minute twenty-eight, she spoke.

"Don't look back."

"What?"

"When you go through security. When you walk to the gate. Don't turn around and look at me. Because if you look at me, I'll run to you. And if I run to you, I won't let go. And if I don't let go, I'll follow you through security and onto the plane and to Seattle and

into your house and I'll never leave and the world will burn."

"That sounds fine."

"Ari."

"Fine. I won't look back."

* * *

Departure Terminal

The airport was bright and cold and full of people who weren't leaving someone they loved. Families with suitcases. Business travelers on laptops. A group of college kids taking selfies. Everyone in motion. Everyone going somewhere. Nobody standing still at the entrance to security, holding a woman's hands, trying to memorize the feel of her knuckles because he won't feel them again until the next time, and there's no date for the next time, there's never a date, there's only "soon" and "soon" is the cruelest word in any language.

"Okay," I said.

"Okay," she said.

I kissed her. Not long. Not short. The exact duration of a kiss between two people in an airport who are trying to fit a week into a mouth.

I let go of her hands. Picked up my bag. Turned toward security.

“Ari.”

I stopped. I didn’t turn around.

“I love you. More than this airport can hold.”

“I love you more than this plane can carry,” I said. The same words from 2019. Our call-and-response. Our liturgy.

I walked to security. Showed my passport. Put my bag on the belt. Walked through the metal detector. Collected my bag. Walked to the gate.

I didn’t look back.

I wanted to. Every step. Every tile on that airport floor was a negotiation between the part of me that promised and the part of me that was already breaking. My neck was a battlefield. Every muscle wanted to turn. To see her one more time. To catch whatever expression she was wearing — crying, waving, standing still, already gone.

I didn’t look back.

I sat at the gate and put my head in my hands and stayed like that until they called boarding. A man in a plastic chair in an airport in India with his head in his hands. Nobody in that terminal thought: that man just left a woman at the curb and promised not to turn around and it’s costing him everything he has.

* * *

The Flight

Eighteen hours. Two connections. The first leg was four hours. I had a window seat. The plane took off and turned and for three seconds, through the scratched plastic of the window, I could see the city below. Her city. The city where she'd walk back to an auto-rickshaw and ride home and close the blue door and become a wife again.

Three seconds. Then clouds.

I put my forehead against the window and closed my eyes and replayed the week. Not the sex. The morning eggs with minibar butter. The temple that smelled like jasmine. The kothu parotta fight. The snoring recording she'd never delete. Her blanket-hogging. Her "dei" when she was annoyed, the one Tamil word that sounded like home.

* * *

Seattle — Arrival

The house was cold.

Not temperature cold. April in Seattle is mild. The kind of cold that lives in a house where no one is waiting. No lights on. No food cooking. No television

murmuring. Just still air and closed curtains and the smell of a house that has been breathing by itself for seven days.

Priya's car was in the driveway. She was home. But the house didn't feel like it. The house felt the way it had felt for years — occupied but empty. Bodies present, people absent.

I put my bag down in the hallway. Took off my shoes. The same hallway I'd walked through a thousand times. The same shoes on the same rack. But I was different. Seven days of a woman laughing in a kitchenette had changed the molecular structure of my re-entry.

"How was the trip?" Priya said from the kitchen. Not looking up. Stirring something. Rice, probably. The perpetual rice.

"Fine."

"Good."

That was it. That was the homecoming. Fine. Good. A dead marriage's entire vocabulary.

I went to the couch. My couch. My blanket was still there, folded the way I'd left it. My charger still plugged in. My earbuds on the side table. Everything exactly as I'd left it. Nothing had moved. Nothing had changed. A week of the most alive I'd ever been, and

the evidence of my real life was a folded blanket on a couch that hadn't noticed I was gone.

I sat down. Took out my phone.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *April 2022*

Meera: Are you home?

Ari: Yes.

Meera: How is it?

Ari: Cold.

Meera: Seattle cold or marriage cold?

Ari: Yes.

Meera: 🥺

Ari: Don't. I'm okay.

Meera: You're not okay. I can hear it through the text.

Ari: I'm sitting on the couch. Priya is making rice. The house smells like nothing. I just spent seven days in a room that smelled like you and now I'm sitting in a room that smells like nothing and I don't know how to be here anymore.

Meera: I know.

Ari: How do you do it? How do you go back every time?

Meera: I become someone else. The woman in the hotel room goes to sleep. The wife wakes up. They're different people. The wife can survive anything because she doesn't remember what the hotel room felt like.

Ari: That's not healthy.

Meera: That's not the point. The point is surviving until the next time.

Ari: When is the next time?

Meera: Soon.

* * *

Soon.

Soon. The word that kept us alive and kept us trapped.

I put the phone down. Leaned back on the couch. Stared at the ceiling.

Different ceiling. Same position. A man on his back, staring up, separated from the woman he loves by eight thousand miles and a marriage that neither of them could end.

From the kitchen, the sound of rice being stirred. The steady, rhythmic scraping of a wooden spoon against a pot. The sound of a wife cooking dinner for a husband who was already gone.

I closed my eyes.

In seven days, the memory would start fading. The edges would soften. Her laugh would get quieter. The taste of kothu parotta would blur into the taste of other meals. The feel of her hand in mine would become abstract, a concept instead of a sensation.

That's how distance works. It preserves the love and erodes the evidence. You remember that you felt something. You forget what it felt like.

Except the hair tie. I reached into my jacket pocket. It was still there. Small. Black. Elastic.

I held it in my fist and let it be enough.

* * *

* * *

* * *

PART FIVE: THE UNRAVELING

2022 – 2023

* * *

CHAPTER 19: THE SUSPICION

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *May 2022*

Ari: Who's that in your story?

Meera: What story?

Ari: The Instagram story. The gym one. There's a guy behind you.

Meera: That's my trainer. I told you I started going to the gym.

Ari: You didn't tell me your trainer was a man.

Meera: Does it matter?

Ari: No. Maybe. I don't know.

* * *

It started with a gym story. A man in the background of a fifteen-second Instagram clip. Probably nothing. Probably just some guy holding a clipboard while she did squats.

But “probably” is a word that doesn't survive at 3 AM. At 3 AM, on a couch in Seattle, eight thousand miles from the woman you love, “probably nothing”

becomes “possibly something,” and “possibly something” becomes “definitely something I need to ask about,” and by morning you’ve constructed an entire affair from a blurry figure in the background of a social media post.

* * *

I need to tell you what I’m not proud of. Because this novel isn’t a story about a hero. It’s a story about a man. And this is the part where the man becomes ugly.

After I came back from India, I was different. Not better different. Sharper. More watchful. The seven days had been the best of my life, but they’d also cracked something open, a proximity to happiness so intense that the thought of losing it made me vigilant in ways that weren’t healthy.

I started monitoring her. Not with software or spy apps. With attention. The kind of attention that used to make her feel seen now made her feel surveilled.

When did she last come online? Why was she active at 2 AM but hadn’t messaged me? Who liked her photos? Why did that guy comment a heart emoji? Why was her call shorter today? Was someone else in the room? Could I hear a voice in the background?

I was becoming the detective of a crime that hadn't been committed. Or had it? That was the problem. I didn't know. And not knowing was worse than any truth.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *June 2022*

Ari: You were online at 1 AM but didn't text me.

Meera: I was checking on the baby. She woke up.

Ari: For thirty minutes?

Meera: She was fussy. I had to rock her back to sleep. Why are you tracking when I'm online?

Ari: I'm not tracking. I just noticed.

Meera: That's tracking, Ari.

* * *

She was right. It was tracking. And I knew it was tracking. And I hated myself for doing it. But the fear of losing her again, the memory of those thirteen unanswered calls, the year of silence, the grey ticks that almost broke me, had rewired my brain into a surveillance system.

Every unexplained absence was the ghosting starting again. Every short call was the beginning of

another year of nothing. Every man in her orbit was the person she'd replace me with.

I was poisoning the water I was drinking from. And I couldn't stop.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages July 2022

Ari: Are you still seeing that trainer?

Meera: I go to the gym three times a week. He's there. He trains me. That's it.

Ari: You mentioned him three times this week. His name is Karthik, apparently. He makes you laugh, apparently. He taught you to do deadlifts, apparently.

Meera: He's my trainer. That's what trainers do.

Ari: Trainers don't text you at 10 PM about "recovery stretches."

Meera: How do you know what time he texts me?

Ari: Because you told me last Tuesday. You said "Karthik just sent me this stretch video" and it was 10 PM your time.

Meera: You're keeping timestamps now?

Ari: I'm paying attention. There's a difference.

Meera: Is there?

* * *

Here's what I know now that I didn't know then: I was right. Not about sex. Not about an affair. But about the attention.

Karthik was paying attention to her. In her city. In person. Three times a week, a man who wasn't her husband and wasn't trapped behind a screen was standing next to her, correcting her form, making her laugh, texting her stretching videos at 10 PM. He was present in a way I could never be from eight thousand miles away.

Did she have feelings for him? I don't know. I never asked her directly, and she never told me. But I know what attention does to a woman who's been starved of it. I know because I watched it happen with me. A man on TikTok played a song she recognized and three months later she was crying his name into a phone. That's the power of being noticed.

Someone was noticing her. In the gym. In her city. In the time zone where her body actually lived.

And I was on a couch in Seattle, tracking timestamps.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *July 2022*

Ari: Does he know about me?

Meera: Nobody knows about you. You know that.

Ari: That bothers me too.

Meera: What do you want me to do? Put up a billboard?

Ari: I want you to leave your husband. That's what I want. I've wanted it for four years.

Meera: ...

Meera: I'm working on it.

Ari: Don't say "working on it." Don't say "soon." Give me something real.

Meera: I don't know what you want me to say.

Ari: The truth. Just the truth.

Meera: The truth is I'm scared. The truth is I have a child and no income and a husband who will make my life hell if I leave. The truth is I love you but love doesn't pay rent.

Ari: I'll support you. I've told you that.

Meera: From eight thousand miles away? How?

* * *

That question, "from eight thousand miles away, how?", was the knife that cut through every romantic delusion I'd built. Because she was right. I could love her from across an ocean. I could make her come through a phone screen. I could fly to India twice and

open her body and her heart. But I couldn't pay her rent. I couldn't protect her from her husband. I couldn't be a father to the child I'd once believed was mine. I couldn't be there at 3 AM when the baby cried or at 7 AM when he switched from perfect to predator.

I could give her everything except the one thing she needed: presence.

The frustration of that impotence, the rage of loving someone you can't reach, was what was turning me into a man I didn't recognize.

* * *

Then the pregnancy.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *August 2022*

Meera: I need to tell you something.

Ari: Those words again.

Meera: I'm pregnant.

* * *

The room went white.

Not mine . It wasn't his. It COULDN'T be mine. I was eight thousand miles away. I hadn't touched her

since April. Four months. The math was irrefutable.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *August 2022 — continued*

Ari: Whose is it?

Meera: His.

Ari: You told me he forces you.

Meera: He does.

Ari: Then how—

Meera: How do you think? He forced me. Multiple times. You know this happens.

Ari: I thought you were going to resist more. I thought—

Meera: Resist MORE? Do you hear yourself? He's twice my size. He doesn't ask. He doesn't care if I resist. I've told you this a hundred times.

Ari: I know. I know. I'm sorry. I just—

Meera: You just what?

Ari: I just can't keep hearing that another man is inside you. Even if it's force. I can't. It's breaking me.

Meera: And you think it's not breaking ME?

* * *

She was right. Again. She was always right in the ways that mattered most. She was the one being violated and I was making it about my feelings. She was the victim and I was centered in the narrative. She was drowning and I was complaining about the splash.

I knew this. Intellectually, I knew this. But emotions don't read the intellectual memo. They just burn.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *September 2022*

Ari: What are you going to do?

Meera: I'm not keeping it.

Ari: An abortion?

Meera: Yes.

Ari: Are you sure?

Meera: I already have one child I'm raising in hell. I'm not bringing another one into this.

Ari: I'm sorry.

Meera: Don't be sorry. Be here. That's all I need.

Ari: I'm here.

* * *

She aborted the baby. In a clinic in her city. Alone. She couldn't tell her husband. He'd want to keep it. Another chain. She couldn't tell her family. They'd want to know how she got pregnant if the marriage was so bad. She couldn't tell me in real time because the time zone meant I was asleep when she was in the procedure room.

She texted me after.

* * *

WhatsApp Message *September 2022, 3:14 AM PST*

Meera: It's done. I'm home. I'm okay.

* * *

Three sentences. The tightest summary of heartbreak I've ever read. "It's done. I'm home. I'm okay." Twelve words covering a universe of pain.

I was asleep when she went through it. Asleep in Seattle while the woman I loved lay on a clinic table in India, alone, ending a pregnancy that was the product of rape, and I didn't even know until I woke up and checked my phone and saw three sentences that rearranged my understanding of what she was surviving.

* * *

I couldn't shake it: she'd been having sex with her husband. Whether forced or not. The pregnancy was proof. Physical, undeniable proof that another man's body had been inside hers.

My ten percent . That pilot light of suspicion that had been burning since the first pregnancy flared into something larger. Was it ALWAYS force? Every single time? Was there never a moment when she didn't resist? When she let it happen because resisting was more exhausting than enduring?

If so, was that still force? Where's the line between a woman being raped and a woman too tired to fight? Does the distinction even matter?

It mattered to me. And I'm not proud of why.

It mattered because I needed her to be mine. Completely. Entirely. Not shared. Not even involuntarily shared. MINE. And the knowledge that another man's body knew hers, regardless of consent, was a splinter I couldn't remove.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App October 2022

"I am becoming someone I don't like."

“The suspicion is a living thing. It sits in my chest and it breathes. It wakes up every time she takes too long to reply. Every time she mentions a name I don’t recognize. Every time I calculate the time zone and wonder where she is at this specific moment.”

“This isn’t love anymore. This is surveillance with a heartbeat.”

“But I can’t stop. Because the one time I trusted completely — the baby, the forehead, ‘it could be yours’. It turned out to be a lie. Maybe not a malicious lie. Maybe a hopeful one. But still a lie. And once you’ve been lied to by the person you trust most, you start auditing everything.”

“I’m auditing her. And she can feel it. And it’s killing us.”

* * *

She could feel it. The interrogations disguised as conversations. The questions with questions underneath them. The temperature checks that were really trust tests.

“You’re different,” she said one night. “You’re watching me like I’m a suspect.”

“I’m not,” I said.

“You are. And I understand why. But it’s suffocating me.”

“Then give me something to hold onto. Leave him. Come to me. End the suspicion by ending the situation.”

“I will.”

“When?”

“Soon.”

* * *

Soon.

The word that had been a painkiller was now a trigger. I heard it and something in me snapped, not outwardly, not dramatically, but internally. A wire pulled too tight finally vibrating at a frequency only I could hear.

The fights got worse. More frequent. Louder. Meaner. We said things we couldn’t unsay. She called me controlling. I called her a liar. She hung up. I called back. She didn’t answer. I spiraled. She texted at 3 AM: “I love you but I can’t breathe.” I texted back: “Then LEAVE and breathe with me.” She didn’t reply.

The pattern wasn’t just repeating. It was accelerating. Spinning faster. Getting louder. And neither of us knew how to stop it because stopping

meant admitting that this beautiful, impossible, ocean-spanning love story was eating us alive.

* * *

Meanwhile, in the same house where all of this was happening, the silent house, the dead marriage house, I tried to rekindle things with Priya.

I know. I know how that sounds. How can a man be fighting with his lover about commitment while simultaneously trying to restart his marriage? The answer is: desperation has no logic. When one lifeline is fraying, you grab for anything. Even the rope you'd already let go of.

* * *

Text Messages — Ari to Priya *November 2022*

Ari: Can we talk tonight? Really talk?

Priya: About what?

Ari: Us. Where we are. Where we're going.

Priya: We're fine.

Ari: We're not fine. We haven't been fine for years.

Priya: I don't want to do this right now.

Ari: When, then?

Priya: I don't know.

* * *

She didn't want to do this. Not now. Not ever. The conversation about our marriage was as unwelcome as the marriage itself.

I understood. Finally, clearly, with a clarity that only comes from being refused by everyone at once. That Priya's distance wasn't indifference. It was protection. She knew. Maybe not the specifics. Not the name, not the country, not the hotel rooms. But she knew something had been taken from the marriage that wasn't coming back. And her distance was the wall she'd built to survive it.

I had betrayed her. Not just with Meera. With years of emotional absence. With the TikTok Lives that mattered more than dinner. With the phone calls at midnight that she never asked about because asking would confirm what she already felt.

She was hurting. And I was the one who'd hurt her. And now I was trying to rekindle a fire that I myself had put out.

* * *

Meera wouldn't leave. Priya wouldn't engage. I was suspended between them like a man hanging from two

ropes, each one too thin to hold his weight, neither one
willing to let go.

Crowded loneliness in the world.

* * *

CHAPTER 20: THE BREAK

* * *

Incoming Call — WhatsApp *March 2023 Caller:*
Meera Duration: 11 minutes

* * *

Eleven minutes. After five years of four-hour calls, eleven minutes is how long it takes to end a love story.

* * *

She didn't start with "I need to tell you something." She didn't start with "we need to talk." She started with silence. Ten seconds of nothing after I picked up. Just her breathing on the other end. The breathing I'd memorized, the breathing I could read like sheet music. This time, the music was wrong. Flat. Resolved. The breathing of someone who's already made a decision and is just looking for the first sentence.

"I can't do this anymore," she said.

Four words. Delivered quietly. Not angry. Not crying. Just... finished. The way someone says “I can’t” when they’ve tried everything and the trying itself has become the problem.

“What do you mean?” I said. Even though I knew exactly what she meant.

“Us. This. The calls. The fights. The ‘when.’ The ‘soon.’ The whole thing. It’s become toxic, Ari. You know it has.”

* * *

Toxic.

She used that word. And it landed in my stomach like a stone because she was right. The love that had once been oxygen had become carbon monoxide . Still filling the room, still being breathed in, but slowly, invisibly poisoning both of us.

The suspicion. The monitoring. The fights about the trainer, the husband, the online status, the reply times. The accusations I’d disguised as questions. The control I’d disguised as concern. The jealousy I’d disguised as love.

She wasn’t wrong. It had become toxic. And I was at least half the reason why.

* * *

The call — reconstructed from memory

Meera: I love you. I need you to know that. I love you more than I've ever loved anyone. But the love isn't enough anymore. Not when every conversation ends in a fight. Not when I'm scared to tell you about my day because you'll find something suspicious in it. Not when I feel like I'm being interrogated by the person who's supposed to be my safe place.

Ari: I'm sorry. I know I've been—

Meera: It's not about sorry. Sorry doesn't fix the pattern. We've been in this pattern for two years. Fight, make up, fight harder, make up harder. It's a spiral. And it's getting tighter. And I can't breathe inside it anymore.

Ari: Then let me change. Give me a chance to—

Meera: You've been saying that too. "Let me change." "Give me time." Those are my words thrown back at me. And I know how hollow they sound because I'm the one who taught you.

Ari: That's not fair.

Meera: None of this is fair. Fair left the building five years ago.

* * *

I tried to fight it. Of course I did. Five years of love doesn't accept an eleven-minute eviction notice without resistance.

I told her I'd stop the suspicion. I told her I'd trust blindly if that's what it took. I told her I'd never ask about her husband again. I told her I'd wait. Forever, if necessary. Without pressure.

She listened. And then she said the thing that ended it:

"I don't want to be waited for anymore. I want to be free. From him AND from the guilt of not being able to give you what you need."

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *After the call*

Meera: Please don't hate me.

Ari: I could never hate you.

Meera: I know this hurts. It hurts me too. More than you know.

Ari: Then why?

Meera: Because I'd rather lose you while we still love each other than watch us destroy the love trying to hold onto it. If we keep going, we'll end up hating each other. And I can't live in a world where you hate me.

Ari: I could never hate you.

Meera: You say that now. But you were getting close. I could hear it in the fights. The contempt creeping in. And I won't let it get there. I won't.

Ari: So you're protecting the memory of us by killing the reality of us?

Meera: Yes. Exactly that.

* * *

"Protecting the memory by killing the reality."

I typed that as an accusation. But reading it now, years later, I see it for what it was: the kindest exit either of us had managed in years.

She was cutting the cord before the love rotted. Before the suspicion turned to certainty. Before the fights turned to cruelty. Before the man who'd once made her come with his voice became the man who made her cry with his accusations.

She was saving us from the worst version of ourselves. And I was too deep in the wreckage to see it.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App March 2023

"She left."

“Five years. Two trips to India. A thousand video calls. A possible child. Squirting. ‘Soon.’ All of it. Done. In eleven minutes.”

“I’m sitting in my car in the driveway. The same driveway. The same house. The same silence. But this time there’s no phone that might ring. No 2 AM call to wait for. No voice on the other end saying ‘I miss you.’”

“This is what nothing actually sounds like.”

* * *

Then the truth came.

Not slowly. Not in pieces. All at once. Like a dam breaking.

She told me herself. She had to — a pregnant belly doesn’t hide behind a breakup text.

And the math I did in my head was instant. Cruel. The math of a jealous man, not a rational one: if she’s pregnant, she let him. Not just the forced times. Not just the nights she described as endurance. She let him inside her, willingly enough for it to happen again. That was the story my jealousy wrote. That she’d opened her body to her husband the way she’d opened it to me — and that the pregnancy was proof she hadn’t fought hard enough. Or hadn’t wanted to fight at all.

I was angry. I was jealous. And underneath both of those, the thing I couldn't say out loud: I felt like a fool. Like she'd been playing me. Five years of "he forces me," five years of "I can't stop him," five years of me swallowing my rage every time I imagined his hands on her body — and now she was pregnant. Again. Which meant maybe the story I'd been told wasn't the whole story. Maybe some of those nights weren't what she said they were. Maybe I'd been the idiot across the ocean, crying for a woman who was going to bed with her husband and letting me believe it was always violence.

I know how that sounds. I know what it makes me. A man who turned a woman's suffering into his own betrayal narrative because his ego couldn't survive the alternative: that her body was never his to claim, and that what happened in her bedroom had nothing to do with him.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *April 2023*

Ari: You're pregnant again. By him.

Meera: Ari...

Ari: Which means you've been sleeping with him. Not just the forced times. You're pregnant, Meera.

That doesn't happen from force alone. Not twice.

Meera: ...

Ari: Tell me the truth. You owe me that. After five years. Tell me the truth.

Meera: He's my husband. We live in the same house. I told you a hundred times . I can't always stop him.

Ari: That's not what I'm asking. I'm asking if there were times when you DIDN'T TRY to stop him. Times when it wasn't force. Times when you just... let it happen. Or wanted it.

Meera: You don't understand what it's like to live in that house.

Ari: Answer the question.

Meera: ...

Meera: At some point, I stopped resisting. Yes. Because resisting was futile. It didn't change anything. He did what he wanted regardless. So yes. I stopped fighting it. Is that what you wanted to hear?

Ari: I don't know what I wanted to hear.

Meera: Now you know. And I'm sorry.

* * *

I stared at that message for an hour.

"I stopped resisting."

Three words that retroactively rewrote five years of my life. Every time she'd said "he forces me": was that the whole truth? Or was it the version of the truth that kept me? The version that made me the hero and him the villain and her the helpless victim caught between?

The truth, as it always is, was messier than any version. He did force her. That was real. The violence was real. The rapes were real. But there were also times when the lines blurred. When exhaustion looked like consent. When a woman too beaten down to fight was also a woman who'd stopped trying to escape.

Somewhere in those blurred lines, my suspicion, the suspicion she called toxic, the suspicion she said was destroying us, had been at least partially right.

I was right. And being right cost me everything.

* * *

The child. The first one. The one with "my forehead."

The child grew. Features sharpened. And the truth that had been hiding in baby fat and ambiguity emerged in the undeniable architecture of a face that looked nothing like mine.

She confirmed it. Quietly. Almost as an afterthought.

“The baby is his. I think I always knew. I’m sorry I let you believe.”

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *April 2023*

Ari: Four years. You let me believe for four years.

Meera: I know.

Ari: Why?

Meera: Because you needed to believe it. And I needed you to stay.

Ari: So it was a leash.

Meera: It was survival. Both of ours.

* * *

“Because you needed to believe it. And I needed you to stay.”

I read that line and I understood something I’d been avoiding for five years: we had both been using each other. Not maliciously. Not cruelly. But with the unconscious efficiency of two drowning people who grab onto each other and mistake the grabbing for swimming.

She used me as her escape from a violent marriage. I used her as my escape from a dead one. We called it

love, and it WAS love, real and deep and devastating, but it was also two life rafts lashed together in the middle of an ocean, each one believing the other was a ship.

Neither of us was a ship. We were both just trying not to drown.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App May 2023

"The baby isn't mine. She was sleeping with him. The 'force' wasn't always force. The 'soon' was never going to come. The 'commitment' was a word she used to keep me calling."

"And I loved her through all of it. That's the part that doesn't make sense. I loved her KNOWING, on some level, that parts of it weren't true. I loved the lie because the lie was the only warm thing in my life."

"What does that make me?"

"Human. I think it makes me human."

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 21: THE EDGE

* * *

WhatsApp Voice Note — Ari to Meera May 2023,
2:33 AM PST Duration: 3:47

[Yelling. Not the controlled kind. The kind that comes from a place so deep it bypasses every filter, every mask, every year of learning to be reasonable.]

“FIVE YEARS. Five fucking years, Meera. I flew across the world for you. TWICE. I held you when you cried. I made you feel things your own husband never made you feel. I believed the baby was mine for THREE YEARS. And you were sleeping with him the whole time? The whole goddamn time?”

[Breathing. Heavy. Ragged.]

“You told me he was forcing you. EVERY TIME. That’s what you said. ‘He forces me.’ And I believed you because I loved you and because what kind of monster doesn’t believe a woman who says she’s being raped? But some of it wasn’t force, was it? Some of it was just... life. Your life. The life you chose every time you said ‘soon’ instead of ‘now.’ The life you kept choosing over me.”

[Voice cracking.]

“I gave you everything. EVERYTHING. And you used me. You used my love like a fucking hotel room — somewhere to escape to when your real life got ugly, and somewhere to check out of when you needed to go back to him.”

[Long pause. The sound of something being thrown. A wall being hit.]

“I’m done. I’m done believing. I’m done waiting. I’m done being your 2 AM escape route. Find someone else to save you. I can’t do it anymore.”

[End of voice note.]

* * *

That voice note is the thing I’m most ashamed of in this entire story.

I was right about the facts. I was right about most of them. But because I took every ounce of pain I’d accumulated over five years, the silence, the ghosting, the pregnancy lies, the broken promises, the “soons” that never came, and aimed it at a woman who was already on the ground.

She was being abused. She was trapped. She was a mother of a toddler in a country where divorce is

shame and marital rape isn't a crime. And I screamed at her like she was the one who'd designed the cage.

I wasn't fighting her. I was fighting the situation. But the situation wasn't on the phone. She was.

* * *

She didn't respond for two days.

Two days of silence that felt different from every other silence in our history. Not the ghosting silence of 2020 . That was abandonment. This was something else. This was the silence of a person absorbing a blow. How a body goes quiet right after impact, before the pain registers.

Then, on the third day:

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *May 2023*

Meera: I took pills.

* * *

Two words. My blood went cold.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *May 2023 — continued*

Ari: What pills? How many? Are you okay? Meera
ANSWER ME

Meera: Paracetamol. A handful. I'm okay. I threw up.

Ari: Oh my God. Oh my God. Are you in the hospital?

Meera: No. I'm home. The baby is with my mother. I'm fine.

Ari: You're NOT fine. You just tried to—

Meera: I didn't try to kill myself. I just wanted the noise to stop. Your voice. His hands. The baby crying. My mother asking when I'll be a better wife. All of it. I just wanted five minutes of quiet.

Ari: Meera...

Meera: The paracetamol didn't even work. I just threw up and lay on the bathroom floor for an hour. Very dramatic. Very ineffective. Very me.

* * *

She was making jokes. About swallowing pills. About lying on a bathroom floor. About wanting the noise to stop. She was making jokes because if she stopped making jokes she'd have to feel it, and feeling it might actually finish what the paracetamol couldn't.

I had put her there.

Not alone. Not entirely. Her husband's violence put her there. The culture that trapped her put her there. The impossible situation put her there. But my voice, my screaming accusing righteous voice in a 3:47 voice note at 2 AM, had been the last weight on a scale that was already tipping.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App May 2023

"She took pills because of me."

"Not just because of me. Because of everything. But my voice was the last thing she heard before she decided that swallowing a handful of paracetamol was preferable to feeling what she was feeling."

"I screamed at a woman who was being raped. I screamed at a woman who was trapped. I screamed at a woman who loved me the only way she knew how. Imperfectly, incompletely, from inside a cage she didn't build."

"And she went to the bathroom and tried to make the noise stop."

"What kind of man does that make me?"

* * *

I stopped.

Not gradually. Not through a process of reflection and growth. I stopped when I saw the edge of a cliff and realized the next step was fatal. Immediately. Completely. With the visceral understanding that one more step in this direction would destroy someone.

No more screaming. No more accusations. No more interrogations disguised as concern. No more voice notes that sounded like weapons.

I pulled back. I softened. I became, overnight, a man who chose silence over cruelty. I hadn't healed . I hadn't. But because the alternative was watching the woman I loved swallow more pills, and that was a weight my soul could not carry.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *May 2023*

Ari: I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. For the voice note. For all of it.

Meera: I know.

Ari: I will never speak to you like that again. I don't care what you've done or what you tell me. Nothing justifies what I said.

Meera: You were hurt.

Ari: That doesn't — I don't know. I'm sorry. That's all I've got.

Meera: ...

Meera: That's the first time a man has ever said that to me.

* * *

“That's the first time a man has ever said that to me.”

Her husband hurt her and called it love. I hurt her and called it justified anger. And in that moment, the distance between me and him was smaller than I'd ever allowed myself to see.

Not the same. I know that. He raped her. I yelled at her. The magnitude is different. But the mechanism, a man who takes his pain out on a woman because she's the closest body available, that mechanism was identical.

Recognizing that was the beginning of everything that came after.

* * *

She recovered. The paracetamol hadn't done any real damage. It was, as she'd said, dramatic and ineffective. A cry for help shaped like a suicide attempt. A

woman's body saying what her mouth couldn't: *I can't take any more pressure from any direction.*

We talked more gently after that. The rawness of the edge, the real edge, the one where a woman swallows pills, had scared us both into a temporary truce. Not reconciliation. Not reunion. Just... quieter. Softer. Two people who'd been screaming at each other suddenly whispering, because they'd seen what screaming leads to.

* * *

The pregnancy continued. She was still carrying his child. The one conceived in the weeks after our breakup. The one she couldn't abort this time. I never asked why. Maybe she was too far along. Maybe she'd decided differently. Maybe she was too exhausted to make another trip to a clinic alone.

She kept the baby.

Two children now. Both his. Both born inside a marriage that should never have existed. Both innocent of everything their parents had done and failed to do.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *August 2023*

Meera: The baby is born. A boy this time.

Ari: Is he healthy?

Meera: Yes. He's perfect.

Ari: I'm glad. Congratulations.

Meera: That's a strange word for this situation.

Ari: Maybe. But a healthy baby is always worth congratulations. Regardless of everything else.

Meera: Thank you. For being kind. After everything.

Ari: I'm done being unkind. I learned what that costs.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 22: THE BATHROOM FLOOR

★ *Meera's POV*

* * *

WhatsApp — Voice Note Received *From: Ari* ❤️

May 2023, 2:33 AM PST / 3:03 PM IST Duration:

3:47

Played once. Not twice.

* * *

The first thirty seconds were enough.

She knew what was coming from the first breath. Not the words. The register. The place in his body where the sound originated. Deep. Below the ribs. The place where men keep the things they can't say calmly, the things that have been composting for months, turning into something toxic and pressurized.

She pressed play and his voice filled the kitchen where she was heating milk for her daughter.

FIVE YEARS.

She turned the volume down. Not off. Down. Low enough that her daughter, watching Peppa Pig in the next room, wouldn't hear a man screaming about the years he'd wasted on her mother.

She listened to the whole thing. Standing in the kitchen. Holding a saucepan of milk that she'd forgotten was on the stove. The milk boiled over sometime during the second minute. She watched it foam over the rim and hiss on the burner and didn't move. The voice in her ear was louder than the hiss.

"You used me. You used my love like a fucking hotel room."

The milk ran down the side of the stove and pooled on the counter. She'd clean it later. Or she wouldn't. It didn't matter. Nothing about the physical world mattered while his voice was a fist in her ear.

"Find someone else to save you."

The voice note ended. 3:47 of a man unloading five years of pain onto the only woman who'd ever tried to love him back.

Meera put the phone on the counter. Turned off the burner. Wiped the milk with a cloth. Rinsed the cloth. Wrung it out. Hung it on the hook by the sink. Every movement deliberate. Every gesture small and precise. The choreography of a woman on autopilot.

Her daughter called from the living room: “Amma! More juice!”

“One minute, kannu.”

She poured the juice. Apple. Her daughter’s favorite. Brought it to the living room. Sat on the floor beside her. Watched Peppa jump in a muddy puddle. Her daughter laughed. Meera’s mouth made the shape of a smile. The rest of her was somewhere else.

* * *

The voice note was still playing in her head. Not on the phone. In the tissue behind her eyes. In the muscle memory of her jaw, which had clenched so tight during minute two that her molars were still aching.

“You told me he was forcing you. EVERY TIME.”

He was right. She had told him that. And it was true. Most of it. Not all of it. Not the parts she’d never told anyone because the truth was more complicated than “he forces me” and the complicated truth doesn’t fit in a WhatsApp message at 2 AM.

The complicated truth: sometimes Vikram forced her. Sometimes she let him because saying no was more exhausting than the act itself. Sometimes she initiated because the guilt of the affair made her think she owed her husband something, and the only

currency he accepted was her body. Sometimes she lay still and felt nothing and that was its own kind of violence — the violence of a woman going through the motions of a marriage because the alternative was a word she couldn't afford: divorce.

None of that made Ari wrong. It made him incomplete. But incomplete and wrong feel the same when someone is screaming.

* * *

Meera's Internal Inventory — 3:17 PM IST

Things that are true right now: 1. The man I love just told me to find someone else to save me. 2. The man I married will be home in two hours. 3. My daughter is watching Peppa Pig and asking for more juice. 4. The milk has burned onto the stove and will take twenty minutes to scrub. 5. My mother called this morning to ask when I'll give her a grandson. 6. I haven't slept more than four hours in a row since 2019. 7. I am twenty-nine years old and I am very, very tired.

* * *

Vikram came home at 5:30. She heard the door. The shoes being placed. The briefcase on the table. The

same sounds, the same sequence, every day for six years. He kissed their daughter's head. Said "what's for dinner" without looking at Meera. She said "rice and rasam." He said "again?" She said nothing.

Dinner was quiet. Their daughter babbled. Vikram looked at his phone. Meera pushed rice around her plate and thought about the voice note and the milk on the stove and the word "hotel room" and the way Ari had said "fucking" like it was a weapon and not a word.

She bathed the baby. Read her a story. Put her to bed. Kissed her forehead. Stood in the doorway counting breaths. Not ten this time. She lost count at twenty.

Vikram was in the bedroom. She could hear the TV. Cricket. Always cricket.

She walked to the bathroom.

* * *

The bathroom was small. Green tiles. A mirror with a crack in the upper corner that had been there since they moved in and that Vikram kept saying he'd fix and never did. A tube light that buzzed. A medicine cabinet with a magnetic latch that never closed properly.

She opened the cabinet. Not with intent. Not with a plan. She opened it the way you open a fridge at 3 AM — not because you're hungry but because you're awake and the light is comforting and your hands need something to do.

Paracetamol. A strip of ten. White tablets in foil blisters. She'd bought them last week for her daughter's fever. Five left.

She popped one out. Held it in her palm. Small. White. The size of a fingernail. Harmless.

She popped another. And another.

She wasn't thinking. That was the thing she'd never be able to explain. She wasn't standing in a bathroom making a decision about living or dying. She was standing in a bathroom where the tube light buzzed and the mirror was cracked and the tiles were cold under her feet and a man's voice was still screaming in her skull and another man was watching cricket ten feet away and a baby was sleeping across the hall and her mother wanted a grandson and the milk had burned and the rasam was too thin and she was twenty-nine and she was tired and she just wanted the noise to stop.

Not her life. The noise.

Five tablets in her palm. She put them in her mouth. Swallowed with water from the tap. Cupped in

her hand. The water was warm. It's always warm in this city.

She stood there. Waiting. For what? For quiet? For numbness? For the world to pause long enough for her to catch her breath?

Nothing happened. Paracetamol doesn't work like that. It's not a sedative. It's not a tranquilizer. It's a fever reducer that, in large doses, destroys your liver over seventy-two hours. But she didn't know that. She knew it was medicine and she wanted the noise to stop and medicine is what you take when something hurts.

Two minutes later, her stomach turned.

* * *

She knelt on the green tiles. The floor was cool against her knees. She vomited into the toilet — bile, water, half-dissolved tablets, the rasam she'd barely eaten. Her body rejecting what her mind had offered it. An involuntary no from a body that had forgotten how to say no to anything else.

She vomited until there was nothing left. Then she sat on the floor. Back against the bathtub. Knees drawn up. Head back. Eyes on the ceiling.

The ceiling.

The same ceiling she went to when Vikram was on top of her. The same ceiling she went to when Ari's calls rang unanswered. The ceiling that was the only place nobody could reach her. But she wasn't floating to it now. She was looking at it from below. From the floor. From the lowest point a body can occupy in a room.

The tube light buzzed. The crack in the mirror caught the light at an angle. The toilet was still running. She should flush it. She didn't.

She sat on the bathroom floor for fifty-seven minutes.

She knew because she counted. Not the minutes. The sounds. Vikram changed channels fourteen times. A dog barked outside in three bursts of four. The neighbors' TV played a song she recognized — something from a film she'd watched as a girl, before she was a wife, before she was a mother, before she was a woman on a bathroom floor.

Fifty-seven minutes of sitting with the noise finally quiet. Not because the paracetamol had worked. Because the vomiting had emptied her. Literally. And an empty body is a quiet body. There was nothing left to digest. Nothing left to process. Nothing left to feel. Just tiles and buzzing and a crack in a mirror.

* * *

At the end of the fifty-seven minutes, she stood up. Flushed the toilet. Washed her face. Looked in the mirror.

The woman looking back was twenty-nine and looked forty. Swollen eyes. Hair stuck to her forehead. A line of dried vomit at the corner of her mouth. She wiped it with the back of her hand.

“Okay,” she said to the mirror.

Not okay as in everything is fine. Okay as in: I’m still here. I vomited the pills. My daughter is asleep. My heart is beating. Tomorrow I’ll wake up and the noise will come back and I’ll have to find another way to survive it that doesn’t involve a medicine cabinet.

But right now. Right now I’m standing. And standing is enough.

* * *

She picked up her phone from where she’d left it on the counter. Opened WhatsApp.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *May 2023, 10:47 PM IST / 10:17 AM PST*

Meera: I took pills.

* * *

She sent it and sat on the edge of the bathtub and waited.

His response was immediate. Frantic. Capital letters. Question marks stacking up like a man building a tower out of panic.

She answered his questions. Paracetamol. A handful. Threw up. Home. The baby is with my mother. Fine.

“I didn’t try to kill myself. I just wanted the noise to stop. Your voice. His hands. The baby crying. My mother asking when I’ll be a better wife. All of it. I just wanted five minutes of quiet.”

She typed it and it was the most honest sentence she’d produced in nine years of marriage and five years of loving a man in a phone. More honest than “I love you.” More honest than “he forces me.” More honest than any of the beautiful, devastating, perfectly worded messages she and Ari had exchanged across eight thousand miles.

She wanted the noise to stop.

That’s all. That’s everything.

* * *

“The paracetamol didn’t even work. I just threw up and lay on the bathroom floor for an hour. Very dramatic. Very ineffective. Very me.”

She made the joke because Ari needed her to make the joke. She could feel his panic through the screen. The guilt gathering behind his words like weather. He was already calculating: the voice note, the screaming, the pills. $A + B = C$. He was already building the cage of self-blame that he’d carry for months.

So she made the joke. Gave him something to hold that wasn’t just horror. Let him believe the worst was over. Let him believe she was okay.

She wasn’t okay.

But she’d been not-okay for so long that not-okay had a routine. And the routine would resume tomorrow. Coffee for Vikram’s mother. Smile at the right moments. Clear the search history. Carry the stone.

Tonight, one addition: scrub the vomit from the toilet bowl before Vikram notices and asks questions that would require answers she doesn’t have.

* * *

She cleaned the bathroom. Bleach. Scrub brush. The chemical smell was sharp enough to cover whatever the vomiting had left behind. She cleaned until the green tiles gleamed. Until the toilet was white. Until the only evidence of what had happened was a half-empty strip of paracetamol in the cabinet, which she threw in the kitchen trash under a banana peel and an empty milk packet.

She brushed her teeth. Changed into her nightgown. Checked on her daughter, who was sleeping with one fist against her mouth — same position since infancy. Meera adjusted the blanket. Touched her daughter's hair. Whispered something in Tamil that wasn't a word, just a sound, the sound a mother makes when she's reminding herself why she's still here.

She went to bed. Vikram was already asleep. The cricket was over. The room was dark.

She lay on her side. Facing the wall. The usual position. The safe position. And she thought:

I am alive. I don't know why I'm alive. I don't know what I'm alive for. But my daughter is breathing in the next room and my body rejected the pills and tomorrow the sun will come up and there will be rasam to make and milk to heat and a life to perform.

And maybe that's enough. Maybe performance is a kind of survival. Maybe the mask keeps the face intact until the face is strong enough to exist without it.

Maybe.

She closed her eyes.

The ceiling didn't call her tonight. For the first time in years, she stayed in her body. Not because it was comfortable. Because it was hers. Damaged and exhausted and twenty-nine and still, somehow, breathing.

The tube light in the bathroom buzzed faintly through the wall.

She fell asleep to the sound of something she'd survived.

* * *

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 23: THE CAGE

Two months after Meera's bathroom floor. Bellevue, Washington.

* * *

Google Search History *July 2023*

how to save a marriage when she won't talk wife
won't communicate what to do marriage counseling
near me seattle can a marriage survive an emotional
affair signs your wife has given up

* * *

I tried.

I need you to know that. Before I tell you what happened — and it's bad, it's the worst thing I've done, worse than the lying, worse than the hotel rooms — I need you to know I tried. Whatever that's worth. Which might be nothing.

Priya wouldn't talk. Wouldn't fight. Wouldn't engage. She'd perfected this thing where she could be in the same room and be on a different continent. Dinner, couch, bed. Same sequence every night. Same

silence. The fridge making that noise. The clock in the hallway. Her phone screen lighting up — she'd started texting someone more. Her sister, maybe. I didn't ask. I'd lost the right to ask anyone anything.

But I kept trying.

Flowers on Tuesday. She put them in water without looking at me. A note on the counter — “Can we talk tonight?” — that she moved aside to set down her coffee. Tickets to a concert she used to like. She said she was busy. She wasn't busy. We both knew she wasn't busy. But saying “I don't want to go anywhere with you” would've required a conversation, and conversations were the thing she'd stopped having.

Two weeks of this. Flowers wilting on the counter because nobody threw them out and neither of us wanted to be the one who did. What a metaphor. Wasn't trying to be poetic. Just the truth.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *July 2023*

Sameer: How's it going da?

Ari: Bad.

Sameer: Priya?

Ari: She won't even look at me.

Sameer: Give her time bro.

Ari: I've been giving her time for 4 years.

Sameer: You know what I mean.

Ari: I don't know what anything means anymore.

* * *

It happened on a Saturday.

Our daughter was at her parents' house. That was rare — a whole afternoon, no logistics, no bedtime routine, no reason to pretend. I'd been building toward this. I was going to sit her down and talk. Actually talk. Not about bills or school pickup schedules or whether we needed more dish soap. About us. About the dead thing between us that we kept stepping over like furniture we were too tired to move.

I found her in the kitchen. She was doing something on her phone. I stood in the doorway.

"Can we talk?"

She didn't look up. "About what."

Not a question. A wall.

"About us. About where this is going. About whether there's anything left."

She set the phone down. Slowly. Looked at me with this expression I'd never seen before. Not anger. Not sadness. Emptiness. Like looking at a stranger who'd just asked for directions.

“There’s nothing to talk about, Ari.”

“How can you say that? We’ve been married for —”

“I know how long we’ve been married.”

“Then talk to me. Just — talk to me. Please.”

She picked up her phone. Started walking toward the bedroom.

And I reached for her hand.

* * *

Here’s the thing. I can explain it. I can tell you I was desperate. I can tell you I hadn’t been touched by anyone in months — Meera was a voice on a phone, Priya was a silhouette walking away. I can tell you my hand moved before my brain caught up. I can tell you I just wanted her to stop. To turn around. To look at me. To acknowledge that I existed in this house, in this marriage, in her life.

I can tell you all of that. And none of it matters.

Because I grabbed her wrist. And I held it. And she pulled. And I didn’t let go.

Her wrist was warm. Small. I could feel the bones under my fingers, the tendons tightening as she pulled. My hand tightened before my brain registered what my hand was doing.

Three seconds. Maybe five. I don't know. Long enough.

Her eyes. That's what I remember. Not fear — though that was there. Something worse. Confirmation. Like every wall she'd built had just been proven necessary. Every silence justified. Every refusal to engage validated in one grip that lasted three to five seconds that I can never take back.

She pulled free. I let go. Not because I chose to — because her face broke through whatever circuit had shorted in my brain. I stepped back. She stepped back.

"Priya, I —"

"Don't touch me."

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean —"

"Don't. Touch. Me." She looked at me. Still calm. Still that terrible emptiness. "When you touch me, Ari, it feels like being in a public restroom."

The sentence landed like a hand around my throat.

She was holding her wrist. Not because I'd hurt it. Because I'd crossed something. A line I didn't know existed because I'd never been the kind of man who crossed it. Except now I was. I was exactly that man.

She walked to the bedroom. Locked the door. I stood in the kitchen.

Twenty minutes of silence.

Then I heard her voice. Low. Calm. Talking to someone. I pressed my ear to the door like the pathetic creature I'd become, and I heard: "I need to report a domestic disturbance."

* * *

The cops came in eleven minutes.

Two of them. Bellevue PD. One was young — my age, maybe younger. The other one had gray at the temples and the specific tired eyes of someone who'd been to a thousand of these calls and they were all the same.

I opened the front door. I was calm. Polite. Indian politeness that's hardcoded — even while your life is collapsing, you offer chai.

"Sir, your wife called. She says you grabbed her against her will."

"I — yes. I held her wrist. I wasn't trying to —"

"Did you make physical contact against her will?"

That's the thing about the question. It's not "what was your intent." It's not "tell me the context." It's binary. Did you or didn't you.

I opened my mouth. The word was already there. Had been there since the kitchen. Since her wrist. Since the sound she made — not a scream, just a

breath, sharp and final, like a door closing. I knew what I'd done. I knew what the answer was. I knew what it would cost.

“Yes.”

The younger cop's hand moved to his belt. Not the gun. The cuffs. I saw it in slow motion.

“Sir, I'm going to need you to turn around.”

* * *

The handcuffs were cold. I remember that. Cold and tight and they pinched the skin on my left wrist — the bony part. The younger cop did them too tight and the older one adjusted them without saying anything. Professional courtesy for a man they were arresting.

The backseat of a police car smells like industrial cleaner and bad decisions. There's a partition. Plexiglass. Scratched up. Someone had scratched “FTP” into it with something sharp. I stared at those three letters for the entire ride and thought about every choice that led me from a TikTok Live to the backseat of a Bellevue police cruiser.

I didn't cry. I was too confused to cry. This wasn't my life. This was someone else's life. I was a software engineer. I went to temples on Diwali. I had a LinkedIn profile with 2,000 connections and a

recommendation from my VP. Men like me don't get arrested. Except they do. They absolutely do. I was proof.

* * *

Booking

They took my wallet. My phone. My belt. My shoelaces.

The shoelaces. That's when it hit me. Not the handcuffs. Not the backseat. The shoelaces. Because taking a man's shoelaces means they think he might use them to hurt himself. And the fact that this was standard procedure — that enough people in this situation had tried — suddenly I understood the specific gravity of where I was.

Fingerprints. Photo. Left side. Right side. Front. The camera flash.

Name. Date of birth. Address. Emergency contact.

I gave Sameer's number. Not Priya's. Not my parents'. Sameer. Because Sameer was the only person in my life who could know about this without it destroying them.

* * *

The cell was cold.

Not dramatically cold. Not movie cold. Just... cold enough that you notice. Concrete bench. Metal toilet in the corner with no seat and no privacy. Fluorescent light that buzzed at a frequency designed to prevent sleep. A smell — old sweat and something chemical, cleaning product that didn't quite clean.

Five other men.

That's the thing about jail. You expect criminals. You expect dangerous. And some of them were. But most of them were just... men. Men who'd had one bad night. One bad decision. One moment where the gap between who they thought they were and who they actually were became visible to the state of Washington.

There was a teacher. DUI. Middle-aged, khaki pants, loafers with no laces. He sat in the corner and didn't look at anyone. I recognized him. Not literally — I recognized what he was. He was me. A man whose life was supposed to be too respectable for this bench. He kept rubbing his wedding ring like it was a talisman that could teleport him back to his real life.

There were two guys who knew each other. Dealers. They were LOUD. Laughing. Bragging. One of them was telling a story about a shootout — “bro he came at me and I was like BANG” — with hand gestures and

everything, like this was a bar, like this was a Friday night story, like the concrete bench and the fluorescent lights were just ambiance. The other one was hypemanning every detail. “No cap! No cap!” I couldn’t tell if the story was true. I couldn’t tell if it mattered.

And then there was the guy.

He came in a few hours after me. Young. Maybe twenty-two. Eyes going in different directions. High on something — meth, maybe. Something that made him electric. Wired. He was talking before the cops even put him in the cell. Talking to no one. Talking to everyone.

“Yo, fuck all y’all! Fuck these cops! They can’t hold me! I KNOW my rights!”

Nobody responded. The teacher shrank into his corner. The dealers went quiet for the first time all night. Something about this guy’s energy — it wasn’t performance. It was chaos.

He walked to the cell door. Stood right at the bars. Unzipped.

And peed.

Standing. Aiming at the hallway. At the cops. Piss hitting the concrete floor outside the cell, splattering. The fluorescent light catching it. The sound of it.

“YEAH! WHAT YOU GONNA DO?”

Two guards came. Big guys. The kind of big that doesn't need to announce itself. They opened the cell door and the kid swung. Actually swung at them. Wild. Missed by a foot. They had him face-down in three seconds. Knee on his back. Zip ties because he was thrashing too hard for cuffs. He was screaming — not words, just sound. Animal sound. They dragged him out. His shoe came off. It sat in the puddle of his piss for twenty minutes before someone moved it.

The cell was quiet after that.

The teacher was crying. Softly. Into his hands. The dealers weren't bragging anymore — a vocabulary I'd only encountered in songs my daughter wasn't supposed to listen to, suddenly real and three feet away from me all night. I was pressed against the wall, arms wrapped around my knees, staring at a shoe in a puddle of urine under fluorescent light.

This is where I am. This is where the TikTok Lives and the hotel rooms and the midnight calls and the jealousy and the wrist-grab brought me. To a concrete bench, watching a stranger's shoe soak in piss, wondering if my life as I knew it was over.

* * *

Three days.

Saturday night. Sunday. Monday.

No phone. No time. Just the fluorescent buzz and the concrete and the meals that came on trays — white bread, something beige that was allegedly turkey, an apple that was soft in a way that suggested it had been an apple weeks ago. I ate everything. Not because I was hungry. Because eating was the only thing that proved time was passing.

I didn't sleep. Not really. You don't sleep in a place like that. You drift. In and out. The lights never turn off. Someone is always snoring. Or coughing. Or crying. Or having a conversation with someone who isn't there. The sounds layer on top of each other until they become one drone, and you float on top of it, not asleep, not awake, not anything.

But here's what I didn't expect. In the absence of everything — phone, routine, the constant noise of performing a life — something opened up. Space. The kind you spend your whole life avoiding.

Sunday morning. Staring at the ceiling. The fear came first.

My job. Domestic violence arrest. Background check. I'm a tech worker in Seattle — we get background checked for everything. New badge access. Visa renewals. Promotions. Client projects. What if HR finds out. What if it shows up in the system on

Monday. What if I get called in. What if the VP who wrote that LinkedIn recommendation sees the booking photo. What if what if what if.

I ran the math. Because that's what I do. Salary. Mortgage. My daughter's school fees. Health insurance. All of it dependent on a job that was dependent on a clean record that was dependent on me not being the kind of man who grabs his wife's wrist in a kitchen in Bellevue. Except I was. And now a system knew.

The fear was real. Practical. Financial. Even with a green card, a DV conviction could complicate everything — naturalization, travel, the permanent stain on a record I'd spent twenty years keeping clean. I knew engineers who'd been let go for less. The tech industry loves a morality clause when it's convenient.

But underneath the fear. Under it. In the quiet underneath. Something else.

I started thinking about the man who'd ended up on this bench. Not the version I told people — the loyal husband who'd been neglected, the romantic who loved too much, the man caught between two impossible situations. The real one. The one who chose TikTok over dinner with his wife. Who chose Meera over therapy. Who chose jealousy over trust. Who chose to grab rather than let go.

Every choice led here. Not fate. Not circumstance. Choices.

I thought about my father. *Appa*. The quiet man who came home every night at the same time, ate what Amma cooked, watched the news, went to bed. I'd spent my whole life thinking that was weakness. Boring. The absence of passion. Sitting on that bench, I wondered if it was discipline. If showing up — just showing up, same time, same place, no drama — was the thing I'd spent four years proving I couldn't do.

I thought about Meera. Not the love. Not the calls. Not the hotel. The pattern. Every time I couldn't reach her, I spiraled. Every time she went quiet, I burned down something in my real life to get her attention back. She was a mirror — and every time I looked, I saw a man who couldn't survive being alone with himself for five minutes. *Enna da nadakudhu*. What was happening. *Enna aachu enakku*. What had happened to me.

I thought about Priya. Not the wall. Not the silence. The before. The woman who married me. Who believed in the version of me I'd presented. Who kept the house running, our daughter fed, while I whispered into my phone at midnight on a couch she could see from the bedroom door.

And then the later Priya. The one I'd been mythologizing. I'd been telling myself the story where she held everything together while I fell apart. That story is not entirely true. The bills started migrating to my account around year nine. Quietly. One at a time. The cable. Then groceries defaulting to my card. Then the mortgage. She never said a word about it. Neither did I. I just absorbed them, one by one, the way you absorb a slow leak — you don't notice until the floor is wet. By year ten I was funding a household that no longer included me in any way that mattered. I paid for the walls she hid behind. I paid for the bed she faced away in. I paid for the kitchen where she cooked for herself and our daughter and left me to figure out my own meals.

I don't say this to indict her. I say it because the myth of the long-suffering wife doesn't belong to her any more than the myth of the villain belongs to me. We were both doing things to each other that we will never fully account for. That's a marriage. That's this one, anyway.

Three days is a long time when there's nowhere to hide from your own thoughts.

The dealers were asleep. The teacher had been released. A new guy came in — drunk, apologetic, kept saying “my wife is going to kill me” until someone told

him to shut up. The fluorescent light buzzed. I sat. I thought. I couldn't stop thinking.

And for the first time in four years, I didn't reach for my phone. Because I didn't have one. And because — here's the part I don't want to say — the silence was doing something the phone never could.

It was making me honest.

Sunday afternoon I finally cried.

Not about Priya. Not about the arrest. Not about the cell or the food or the light that wouldn't turn off. I cried because I thought about my daughter. Her face when she came home from grandma's house in India and Appa wasn't there. The explanation Priya would have to give or not give. The look on her face that I would never see because I was on a concrete bench in Bellevue staring at a metal toilet.

That broke me.

* * *

Sameer came Monday morning.

He'd talked to Priya. I don't know what he said. I don't know what she said. I know this: she told the prosecutor's office she didn't want to pursue it. She declined to provide a statement. She agreed to let him post bail. She did these things not because she forgave

me — she didn't, she hasn't, maybe she never will — but because our daughter needed a father who wasn't in jail and she was, despite everything, a better person than I deserved.

The release process took four hours. Paperwork. Signatures. A court date I'd have to come back for. A restraining order. Twenty feet. Can't go within twenty feet of her unless she consents. In our own house. Twenty feet in a twelve-hundred-square-foot house is a sentence written by people who've never lived in one. There is no twenty feet in our house. The kitchen is eight feet from the bedroom. The hallway is four. To honor the order, I would have to leave.

Sameer drove me home. We didn't talk for twenty minutes. He drove. I looked out the window. The world was the same — same trees, same traffic, same Bellevue with its clean sidewalks and its Tesla dealerships and its people carrying Whole Foods bags. Same world. Different man looking at it.

Sameer didn't ask if I was okay. He reached into the cup holder and handed me a coffee. Black. Still hot. He'd timed it — bought it while they were processing me, kept the engine running. That's Tamil love. You don't ask a man how he's feeling when you both already know. You hand him something warm and you drive.

We didn't talk for another ten minutes after that.

* * *

The house was empty.

Priya had taken our daughter to her parents'. Her things were still there — she hadn't left, not yet, that would come later — but the house had that specific emptiness of a place where someone has chosen not to be. Different from "she's at work" empty. This was "she's gone because of you" empty.

I stood in the kitchen.

I'd walked past my daughter's room on the way in. The door was open. A stuffed elephant on the floor. The specific violence of an empty child's room when you're the reason it's empty.

The flowers I'd bought two weeks ago were dead on the counter. Brown petals on the granite. Nobody had thrown them out. Nobody had thrown them out and now I was home from jail looking at dead flowers I'd bought to save a marriage I'd already killed.

I showered for forty minutes. Stood under the water until it went cold. Trying to wash off the fluorescent light. The smell. The sound of that kid screaming. The shoe in the puddle. The teacher crying into his hands. My own hands — the same hands that

grabbed her wrist, that held her when she pulled away, that crossed a line I didn't know I was capable of crossing.

I sat on the bathroom floor. Wet. Naked. Forty years old.

Here's what jail taught me that three years of therapy couldn't:

I wasn't the victim of this story.

Not of my marriage. Not of Meera's distance. Not of anyone's silence. I was a man who'd made choices — hundreds of them, thousands of them, starting with a TikTok Live and ending with a wrist-grab in a kitchen in Bellevue — and every single choice was mine. Not fate. Not love. Not desperation. Mine.

The teacher with the DUI. The dealers with the shootout story. The kid who pissed on the floor. We were all in the same cell. Same bench. Same light. We all had stories about how we got there and every story started with "I didn't mean to" or "it wasn't supposed to go this way" or "you don't understand." Same stories. Same bench.

I was not a special case. I was a cautionary tale sitting in my bathroom, dripping on the tile, wondering how many more wrong turns a man gets before the road runs out entirely.

* * *

Google Search History *Monday night, July 2023*

domestic violence charge washington state first
offense dv what happens can you lose your job from dv
arrest custody rights after dv arrest washington
therapist near me accepting new patients

* * *

I started therapy the next day. Not marriage counseling. Not couples work. Solo. Me. A small office in downtown Bellevue with a woman named Anna who had gray hair and glasses and a specific way of sitting that said “I’ve heard worse” before I opened my mouth.

“Tell me why you’re here.”

“I grabbed my wife’s wrist. She called the police. I spent three days in jail.”

She didn’t flinch. Didn’t react. Just nodded. Wrote something down.

“And before that?”

“Before that?”

“What led to that moment?”

And I told her. Everything. Priya. The dead marriage. TikTok. Meera. India. The calls. The

jealousy. The monitoring. The gym trainer. All of it. Four years of compressed secret life, pouring out in a fifty-minute session that went ninety.

She listened. At the end she said one thing.

“You’ve been performing love instead of practicing it. For years. With everyone. Including yourself.”

I didn’t understand it that day. I wrote it down in my phone so I wouldn’t lose it. Then I sat in my car in the parking lot for twenty minutes and couldn’t tell you why.

* * *

I meant it. The voice note, the pills, the bathroom floor, that sequence had burned something out of me. The angry man. The suspicious man. The man who needed to be right more than he needed to be good. That man had seen what his righteousness produced: a woman on a bathroom floor with paracetamol in her stomach, and he’d retired. Permanently.

What replaced him wasn’t yet a King. That came later. But it was at least a man who understood, finally, that love expressed as control is not love. It’s just loneliness wearing a louder voice.

* * *

**Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App September
2023**

"I think about the voice note every day. I wish I could delete it from the universe. Not from my phone. From existence. From the air. From her memory."

"But I can't. And maybe I shouldn't. Because that voice note is the mirror I needed. The one that showed me who I was becoming. And the reflection was so ugly that it stopped me."

"She didn't take those pills because of one voice note. She took them because she was drowning from every direction. But my voice was in the water too. And I have to live with that."

"I think about the cell too. The bench. The fluorescent light that wouldn't turn off. The shoe in the puddle. Three days with nowhere to hide from my own thoughts. Anna says that's where the work started — not in her office, but on that bench. I didn't choose to sit with myself. The state of Washington chose for me. But sitting is sitting. And what I saw, sitting there, was a man who'd spent five years performing love so convincingly he'd fooled everyone. Including himself."

"The voice note. The pills. The wrist. The cell. Four mirrors. Same reflection. A man who called it love and made it everyone else's emergency."

“And Priya. I keep forgetting to count Priya. That’s the worst part — that I can list the damage and still forget the person closest to me. She cooked dinner every night while I whispered to another woman on the couch. She drove our daughter to school while I checked WhatsApp under the covers. She faced the wall at night because somewhere she’d figured out that the man lying next to her had already left. I didn’t hit her with a voice note. I hit her with years of absence disguised as presence. And she absorbed it so quietly that I never even noticed the wound.”

“I’m learning to sit with that fear instead of making it someone else’s problem.”

“It’s the loneliest work in the world. But it might be the most important.”

* * *

PART SIX: ABUNDANCE

2023 – 2027

* * *

CHAPTER 24: PRIYA

★ *Priya's POV*

* * *

Grocery List — Priya's Notes App *October 2023*

Milk (2%) Eggs (dozen) Rice (Basmati, 10 lb)
Sambar powder Coconut oil Dishwasher pods
Tamarind paste

~~Talk to Ari about the electricity bill~~ ~~Talk to Ari~~

* * *

She'd stopped finishing his name on lists. Not consciously. Her thumb just stopped after the second letter. Ar— and then nothing. Like her hand knew before her brain did that there was no point completing a word that had already become a silence.

* * *

Priya knew.

Not everything. Not the hotel rooms or the phone calls at 2 AM or the specific architecture of a five-year

love affair conducted across eight thousand miles. Not the name. Not the face. Not the body. She didn't know Meera existed the way you don't know the name of the disease that's been eating your husband from the inside. You just know he's sick. You know because you live with him. Because you sleep next to the symptoms every night.

She knew the way a woman knows.

The cologne. That was first. 2019. February. He'd never worn cologne to "work trips" before. In twelve years of marriage, Ari's travel preparation was: check passport, pack charger, complain about the flight. Suddenly there was a bottle of something expensive on the bathroom counter, and he was spraying it on his neck with the precision of a man who expected someone to smell him.

She noticed. She ironed his shirts anyway. She set out his travel bag. She made the chai he liked for the morning of his flight. She did all of it with a face that gave nothing away, because she had learned — from her mother, from her mother's mother, from a thousand years of women who knew things they were not supposed to know — that the most powerful thing you can do with knowledge is carry it quietly.

She noticed. She said nothing.

The phone. That was second. He'd always been on his phone — TikTok, the Lives, the music stuff she'd stopped paying attention to years ago. But the phone changed. It migrated from the coffee table to his pocket. From his pocket to his hand. From his hand to face-down on every surface, screen always hidden. He started taking calls in the garage. Started texting with the phone tilted away from her line of sight.

She noticed. She said nothing.

Once, she picked up his phone. He'd left it on the kitchen counter, screen up, unlocked. A notification visible: a name she didn't recognize, a message she read in the half-second before she put it back exactly as she'd found it. She finished washing the dishes. She dried her hands. She went to bed and faced the wall and her heart was absolutely steady, because she had already known, and knowing the name was not new information. It was just the information becoming specific.

The couch. He'd been sleeping on the couch for years. That wasn't new. What was new was how he slept there. Before, the couch was defeat. He lay on it like a man who'd been exiled. After February 2019, the couch was a nest. He had his blanket, his charger, his earbuds. He'd set it up. Made it permanent. Like a man building a home inside the home he was leaving.

She noticed. She said nothing.

* * *

What she didn't say was this: she chose the silence. It wasn't only exhaustion. It wasn't only surrender. There was, underneath the exhaustion, something sharper. Something she couldn't name for a long time because she was a woman who'd been taught that anger is ugly, that a wife's anger is ugliest of all, that the dignified response to betrayal is quiet endurance.

But she was angry.

Not always the cold kind. Sometimes it was right there, close to the surface, looking for a place to go. She learned to keep it contained — she was not a woman who screamed, and she was not going to become one — but containment is not the same as absence. The anger was present in every room they shared. In the way she answered his questions. In the silences she let go too long. In the moments when he reached toward her — not sexually, just the ordinary reaching of a person toward another person — and she became very still, very correct, very much not there.

She stopped touching him. All of it. Not just sex. The hand on the shoulder when she walked by. The feet finding his under the blanket without thinking.

The casual contact of two people who have shared a body of space long enough to stop noticing each other. She withdrew all of it. Systematically. Without announcement. Let him feel the absence and figure out what it meant.

And then she stopped doing the other things too. The small domestic things that constitute a life shared. She cooked — but not for him. She did laundry — but not his. She bought groceries — but not what he ate. She managed the house with the efficiency she brought to everything, and she excised him from the management of it. Quietly. Completely. He came home to a house that ran without him and for him simultaneously — he paid for it, and he was not included in it. His shirts stayed in the hamper. His meals were his problem. If he was hungry, he figured it out. If he needed something clean to wear, he handled it.

She never said: this is because you hurt me. She never said anything. That was the point. She let the architecture do the talking. The house said everything she wouldn't. *You are alone here. You are alone here. You are alone here.* Every day. Without a word.

Not the hot, screaming kind of anger. The cold kind. The kind that doesn't burn out because it doesn't burn — it hardens. Year by year, silence by silence,

turned back by turned back, the anger calcified into something structural. A decision. She stopped touching him not only because she was hurt. She stopped because she had decided that her touch was something he had forfeited. He had taken her presence for granted. He had taken her body for granted. He had taken her loyalty for granted while giving his loyalty somewhere else. And she had decided — quietly, without announcement, without the dignity of a confrontation he could respond to — that she was going to stop giving him the things he'd stopped deserving.

She denied him intimacy the way a board revokes a membership. Without explanation. With procedure. And she watched him shrink from it, confused, reaching for something she'd withdrawn without warning, and she felt — she is ashamed of this, but it's true — a specific, cold satisfaction. The satisfaction of finally being the one who withholds. Of finally being the one who controls the temperature of the room.

The body was first. Then the money.

Not dramatically. She didn't close accounts or hide cards. She just stopped. The electricity bill she'd always paid online — she let it sit. The car insurance renewal — she forwarded the email to him without comment. The mortgage autopay that had always

drawn from her account — she quietly removed it and waited to see how long before he noticed, before he reconfigured it from his side. He did. He said nothing. She said nothing. The bills migrated to his ledger the same way the bed had migrated to her alone: gradually, without announcement, by the logic of whoever was willing to keep showing up.

She was an engineer. She understood load-bearing systems. She understood what happened when you removed support from a structure without saying why.

She is not proud of this. She also doesn't pretend it isn't true.

People assume Priya didn't notice because she didn't care. That's the easy reading. The cold wife. The one who faced the wall. The one who let the marriage die.

The truth is both simpler and more complicated: she noticed everything, she said nothing, and some of the silence was grief and some of it was chosen.

* * *

iMessage Thread — Priya to her sister, Kavitha *March 2019*

Priya: I think Ari is seeing someone.

Kavitha: What??? What makes you think that?

Priya: Cologne. Phone always hidden. “Business trip” to India that he won’t explain.

Kavitha: Did you ask him?

Priya: No.

Kavitha: Priya. ASK HIM.

Priya: And then what? He denies it. I can’t prove anything. We have another fight that ends with him on the couch and me staring at the wall. What changes?

Kavitha: At least you’d know.

Priya: I already know. Knowing the name doesn’t change anything. Knowing the name just gives the pain a face.

* * *

She didn’t ask. Not then. Not after the second trip in 2022. Not when his eyes went red for three days in January 2020 and he said “allergies” and she said “okay” and they both knew that men don’t get allergies that make them sit in their car in the driveway for twenty minutes before coming inside.

She didn’t ask because the question wasn’t “are you seeing someone?” The question was: “Do you want to be here?” And she’d asked that question a hundred different ways over twelve years — with dinner she cooked, with lingerie she bought, with therapy she

suggested, with sex she initiated, with silence she offered — and the answer was always the same.

No.

He didn't want to be here. He hadn't wanted to be here for years. The woman, whoever she was, wasn't the cause. She was the evidence.

* * *

Priya married Ari when she was twenty-two. A good match. Good family. Good job. Good-looking in the way Tamil mothers approve of: fair enough, tall enough, American salary. Her parents were proud. His parents were proud. The wedding was three days of silk and sandalwood and promises made in a language older than anyone in the room.

She'd loved him. That part gets lost in his version of the story, and she understood why. In his telling, the marriage was dead from the start. Cold bed. Wall-facing. Silence. And that's true. By 2018, that's what the marriage was. But marriages don't start dead. They die over time, in small ways, through a thousand choices that nobody remembers making.

Here is what she remembers:

The first two years were good. Not passionate — Priya wasn't a passionate person, and she'd never

pretended to be. She was steady. Warm. Present. She cooked what he liked. She asked about his work. She went to his company dinners and smiled at strangers and drove home in comfortable silence that felt, for a while, like peace.

The sex was fine. Not fireworks. Fine. She'd never had fireworks. She didn't know what she was missing because nobody had told her there was something to miss. In her mother's generation, sex was duty. In her generation, it was supposed to be more, but nobody explained what "more" looked like, so she did what she'd been taught: showed up, participated, didn't complain.

He wanted more. She could feel it. His reaching for her started urgent and ended frustrated. He'd try something new and she'd stiffen, not because she didn't want to but because nobody had taught her how to want. Desire was a language he was fluent in and she was still learning the alphabet.

She tried. She tried lingerie. She tried initiating. She tried the things she read about online in articles with titles like "10 Ways to Spice Up Your Marriage" written by people who'd never had to learn desire from a manual. It felt mechanical. Performative. He could feel it was performative. So he stopped reaching. And

she stopped trying. And the distance became geography.

* * *

Year four, she faced the wall for the first time.

Not because she was rejecting him. Not yet. Because she was exhausted. A twelve-hour day at the office, debugging code that someone else had written badly. A dinner she'd cooked from scratch because his mother was visiting and the woman inspected kitchens like a health department official. A conversation with that same mother about grandchildren — plural, because one was never enough — delivered with the cheerful menace of a woman who considers a single grandchild a personal insult.

Priya lay in bed and faced the wall because the wall didn't want anything from her. The wall didn't need dinner. The wall didn't need an orgasm. The wall didn't need a grandson. The wall was the only surface in her life that expected nothing.

Ari noticed. He didn't say anything. He went to the couch. And the couch became a country, and the wall became a country, and their bedroom became a border between two nations that had forgotten how to negotiate.

* * *

She thought about leaving. Of course she did. Year six. Year eight. Year ten. Each time, the same calculation:

Leave and go where? Back to her parents, who would die of shame before they'd accept a divorced daughter? To an apartment she'd pay for on an engineer's salary while he kept the house? To a life where every Tamil auntie within a five-hundred-mile radius would know, by the end of the week, that Priya Velmurugan couldn't keep her husband?

The math never worked. Not financially. Not culturally. Not emotionally. She didn't have the energy for a divorce. Divorce requires fury or courage, and Priya had neither. She had endurance. And endurance, in the absence of alternatives, looks exactly like acceptance.

There were moments. That's the part that's hard to explain. Moments when she softened. When she let him back in a little — a dinner that went longer than usual, a laugh that surprised her, a night where the distance felt smaller than it had in years. She'd think: maybe. Maybe this is survivable. Maybe we still have something worth saving.

And then she'd remember. Not because she chose to. Because she couldn't stop. The past didn't stay in

the past — it kept showing up. She'd be having a good morning with him and a thought would arrive, unbidden: *he wore cologne for her and he never wore it for me*. She'd be almost relaxed in a conversation and something he said — a word, a tone, a small deflection — would activate the file she kept in the back of her mind, and she'd feel herself closing again. Not a decision. A reflex.

The forgiveness was always provisional. She gave it and immediately started watching for the reason to take it back. She couldn't help it. The trust had been broken too many times, in too many small ways, before she even had proof of anything. By the time she had proof, the forgiveness mechanism was already broken. She'd try to open it and it would jam.

The India trip was the before and after. The first one — 2019, the cologne, the precision of a man who expected to be smelled — she told herself she was imagining things. The second time he came back smelling like someone else's soap, something in her calcified permanently. Not rage. Certainty. She knew. And knowing changed the shape of everything that came after: every brief softening, every provisional forgiveness, every almost-good moment now carried the weight of what she knew underneath it. She was forgiving a man she'd already convicted. The

forgiveness was real. The conviction was also real.
Both things at once, every day, for years.

So she stayed. And he stayed. And they performed a marriage for twelve years, and the performance was so convincing that his parents called every Sunday and said “you two are so stable” and her parents told relatives “they’re settled, very happy” and the word “settled” was doing so much work it should have filed for overtime.

* * *

**Priya’s Journal — Handwritten, kept in her
nightstand drawer July 2022**

“He came back from India today. Another ‘business trip.’ He didn’t smell like cologne this time. He smelled like someone else’s soap. Not ours. Something floral. He showered before he came home, but soap clings to skin in a way that shampoo doesn’t, and I noticed because I notice everything and say nothing.”

“I could ask. I could scream. I could hire a private investigator or check his phone when he sleeps or do any of the things women do on TV when their husbands are unfaithful.”

“But here is the thing I can’t say to anyone, not even Kavitha: I don’t care who she is. I care that she exists. Not because I’m jealous. Because her existence means he found something outside this house that he couldn’t find inside it. And that means the house failed. And I built the house. So I failed.”

“That’s the logic. That’s the trap. The math that keeps women in marriages: if he’s unhappy, I built the wrong life. If I built the wrong life, leaving won’t fix it. If leaving won’t fix it, I might as well stay.”

“Circular. Absurd. And completely airtight.”

“What I don’t write: I am furious. I have been furious for years. Not at her — I don’t have the energy to be furious at someone I’ll never meet. At him. At the specific shape of his betrayal, which is not the woman. The woman is a symptom. The betrayal is that he chose. He chose to take what he needed from somewhere else rather than fight for it here. He chose the path of least resistance, which is always, in a marriage, the exit. And he didn’t even have the courage to leave. He stayed. He stayed and he left and he let me be the one to hold the structure of this marriage while he was somewhere else being held by someone who didn’t yet know the weight of holding him.”

“I am so tired of holding things.”

* * *

She thought about the other woman sometimes. Late at night. While Ari was on the couch whispering into his phone. She'd lie in bed and construct a person from fragments. Young, probably. Indian, probably. Beautiful in the way Priya wasn't — the kind of beautiful that burns instead of warms.

She imagined this woman making him laugh. She imagined him telling this woman the things he used to tell Priya when they were newlyweds and the world was small enough to fit in a shared bed. She imagined his hands on someone else's body, hands that hadn't touched her in years, and the image didn't make her angry.

It made her tired.

A bone-deep weariness that had nothing to do with sleep. The tiredness of a woman who has been competing with a ghost for years and finally understands that the competition was never fair because you can't compete with someone who lives in a phone. You can't compete with fantasy. You can't compete with distance, because distance is kind in a way that proximity never is. Distance hides your flaws. Proximity is nothing but flaws.

The other woman got the cologne. The phone calls.
The whispered voice. The man who tried.

Priya got the silence. The couch. The wall. The man
who'd stopped.

And the terrible, honest truth that she'd stopped
too. That the wall wasn't just a rejection of him. It was
a surrender. The moment she turned away and he
went to the couch, they'd both signed a treaty that
neither of them had the courage to read aloud.

* * *

* * *

There was a man at her church group.

She'd started going in 2021. Not for God — she'd
had a complicated relationship with God since her
mother-in-law started using him as a character witness
in arguments about grandchildren. She went for the
structure. An hour on Sunday mornings where nobody
needed anything from her. Where she could sit in a
row and be anonymous and let someone else's voice fill
the room.

His name was Rajan. He taught secondary school.
He was forty-one, recently divorced, and he brought
homemade biscuits to the post-service tea every week

without being asked. The first time she noticed him was when he asked her opinion about something — not her marital status, not what she did for work, not whether she had children. Her opinion. About a passage from that morning's sermon. As if she were a person with thoughts.

She answered. He listened. She went home and didn't think about it.

The second week, he asked a follow-up question. As if he had remembered what she said. As if what she said had been worth remembering.

She started going every week.

They talked mostly about books. About the city. About the particular exhaustion of living in a culture that expects you to be two things at once — Indian enough for the family, British enough for the office, enough for everyone and nothing entirely for yourself. He understood this in the way only someone who'd lived it could. He didn't offer solutions. He just nodded. He made tea without asking how she took it because he'd noticed.

She noticed that he noticed.

This went on for several months. She told herself it was friendship. She told herself she needed friends — real ones, not the Tamil auntie network that ran on gossip and obligation. She told herself that having a

person who listened was a basic human need and she was simply meeting it.

But she knew.

She knew because she started leaving the house on Sunday mornings with something she couldn't name. Not excitement — she was too controlled for excitement. Something more like aliveness. A low current. The specific awareness of being about to be in a room where someone would look at her like she was there.

She knew because one Sunday he couldn't come — his daughter had a recital — and she sat through the whole hour distracted, annoyed at herself for being distracted, annoyed at him for having a daughter with a recital, and then deeply annoyed at the annoyance itself, because it revealed something she hadn't given herself permission to feel.

She came home that Sunday to find Ari making tea in the kitchen. Something he hadn't done in years. He offered her a cup. She said no. She went upstairs. She sat on the edge of the bed and thought about Rajan pouring tea for her without asking how she took it, and then she thought about the fact that she was thinking about Rajan while Ari stood downstairs in their kitchen trying, for whatever reason, to make her tea, and she felt a flash of something she didn't want to

name. Not guilt exactly. Something uglier. The awareness of herself as a person who was doing a thing she would not be able to explain cleanly.

She kept going.

That's the part she's least proud of. She never acted on it — that was never the question, Priya had a code, physical fidelity was not negotiable, she'd watched her marriage corrode and she would not be the corrosion in someone else's — but she kept going. Kept showing up. Kept accepting the tea he made without asking, kept the Sunday morning current alive, told herself it was friendship because technically it was, because nothing had happened and nothing would, and all of that was true and none of it was the whole truth.

The whole truth was that she was getting something from Rajan that she had stopped giving Ari. Presence. Attention. The warmth of a person who was genuinely glad you were in the room. And she was taking it. Every week. While her marriage was ending in the kitchen downstairs.

And then there was the other thing. The thing about Ari's hands.

At some point — she couldn't say exactly when, only that it was after the second India trip, after the soap smell, after certainty replaced suspicion — she had stopped being able to tolerate his touch. Not just

sexually. The ordinary contact of proximity: his hand on her shoulder, his arm brushing hers in the hallway. Her skin rejected it. When he touched her it felt like being in a public restroom.

She never said that to him. She is saying it now, here, to herself, in the privacy of her own honest accounting, because she is trying to be fair. To everyone. Including herself.

The Rajan thing wasn't revenge. It wasn't even compensation. It was just proof that she was still a person capable of warmth. That the numbness was specific, not total. That she hadn't gone cold everywhere — just in the direction of a man who'd made her cold.

She kept going to the church group right up until she asked Ari to leave. And for a little while after.

She never told anyone. Not Kavitha. Not her therapist. Not the spreadsheet.

The spreadsheet has a column for Notes. That cell she left blank.

* * *

The Day She Decided

It wasn't a fight. There was no revelation, no discovered text, no lipstick on a collar. Those things

happen in movies. In real life, the end of a marriage is quieter. It's a Tuesday evening in October.

He was on the couch. She was in the kitchen. She reheated rice for herself. Poured sambar into a bowl. Did not set a second plate.

He came in eventually. Found something in the fridge. They sat at the same table without speaking. He looked at his phone. She looked at her plate.

And she thought: I am thirty-six years old. I am an engineer. I am competent and intelligent and I have shipped systems that run without failing. Production systems. I have been paged at 3 AM and fixed what was broken and gone back to bed. I am not a person who cannot survive.

And then: I have been surviving this marriage for twelve years. What if I stopped surviving and started living?

The thought was so quiet it almost went unnoticed. Like a bird landing on a windowsill. There and then gone. But it came back. That night. The next morning. The next week. Like a bird that keeps returning to the same sill until you finally open the window.

* * *

iMessage Thread — Priya to Kavitha *November 2023*

Priya: I'm going to ask him to leave.

Kavitha: Are you sure?

Priya: I've been sure for three years. I've been scared for three years. I'm done being scared.

Kavitha: What about Amma and Appa?

Priya: They'll survive. They survived partition. They'll survive their daughter getting a divorce.

Kavitha: Priya...

Priya: I know. I know what it means. I know what people will say. I know Chithi will call me every day for a month asking what I did wrong. I know Amma will cry. I know Appa will go quiet the way he does when he's ashamed.

Priya: But I also know that I'm thirty-six and I sleep alone in a bed I share with a man who's in love with someone else. And I'm tired of being the good wife in a dead marriage. I want to be a living woman in no marriage at all.

Kavitha: I'll be there. Whatever you need.

Priya: I need you to not say "I told you so."

Kavitha: Deal.

* * *

She told him on a Sunday. After brunch. Because she'd read somewhere that difficult conversations go better in daylight, and because Sundays were the only day they were both home and awake at the same time.

"I think we should separate."

He looked at her. Not with shock. Not with devastation. With the expression of a man who's been waiting for a sentence and finally hearing it said aloud. Relief that someone else said it first. Relief that the pretending was over.

"Okay," he said.

One word. Twelve years of marriage and the ending was one word.

She'd prepared for a fight. For tears. For accusations. For "what about what people will say" and "let's try therapy" and all the phrases marriages produce when they're dying and both people know it but neither wants to be the one holding the pillow.

Instead: "Okay."

And then silence. The same silence that had defined them for years, but different now. Not hostile. Not cold. Almost gentle. The silence of two people setting down a weight they've been carrying together and realizing they can both stand taller without it.

* * *

She cried that night. Alone. In the bed that was now just hers. Not because the marriage was over. Because she'd waited so long. Because the years between knowing and acting were years she'd never get back. Because the woman who'd faced the wall at year four could have walked out the door, and instead she'd stayed for eight more years of sambar and silence and sleeping next to a man who whispered someone else's name into a phone.

She cried for the twenty-two-year-old bride who'd believed in silk and sandalwood. For the woman who'd tried lingerie and felt foolish. For the engineer who built systems that never failed and couldn't fix her own marriage. For the daughter who'd carry her parents' shame like a second skin.

She cried for Ari, too. Because he wasn't a villain. He was a man who'd married the wrong woman and punished them both for it for twelve years. He'd never been cruel. Never stopped providing. Never forced her for anything. He'd simply... left. Emotionally. Spiritually. And eventually, by the time she asked him to go, physically.

His crime was absence. And her crime was staying in the room where he wasn't.

* * *

Priya's Journal — Final Entry *December 2023*

“He moved out last week. The house is quiet. Not the old quiet — the quiet of two people ignoring each other. A new quiet. The quiet of one person breathing in a space that’s finally big enough for just her.”

“I found his cologne in the bathroom cabinet. The one he wore on those trips. I picked it up. Smelled it. It wasn’t bad. Woody. Warm. The kind of scent a woman would notice.”

“I hope she noticed. I hope she made him feel whatever he was looking for when he put it on. I hope she gave him the thing I couldn’t give him. Not because I’m generous. Because if all that pain and silence and wall-facing was for nothing — if the woman in the phone didn’t even make him happy — then what was any of it for?”

“I don’t hate her. I don’t know her. I hate the years I lost deciding whether to leave.”

“But the years aren’t lost. They’re mine. I lived them. Badly, quietly, facing the wrong direction. But I lived them. And now I’m going to live the ones that come next facing forward.”

“My name is Priya. It means beloved.”

“I’m going to find out what that feels like.”

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 25: PRIYA AFTER ★

* * *

Priya keeps a spreadsheet of her feelings.

She started it the day the papers went through — not out of irony, which would have required more detachment than she had at the time, but out of habit. Priya is an engineer. Priya has been an engineer for seventeen years. Priya does not trust any system she cannot observe, and in the weeks after the divorce she did not trust herself, which meant she did not trust the system of her own interior, which meant she needed a dashboard.

The spreadsheet has four columns.

Date. Event. Feeling (1–10, valence signed). Note.

The first row says: March 14. Signed. –8. Numb is not zero. Numb is a low negative you mistake for zero.

She has six months of rows.

She does not show this spreadsheet to her therapist. She does not show it to her sister, who has taken up the role of Official Worrier with the grim competence of a younger sibling who has waited her whole life for the older one to stumble. She does not

show it to her parents, who have taken up the role of Nobody. Her parents text her on Sundays about the weather. They do not ask about the divorce. They have not said his name since the week of the papers. This, Priya has come to understand, is how her parents grieve — by editing.

She does not grieve by editing.

She grieves by spreadsheet.

Six months in, the spreadsheet is beginning to show a pattern.

The valence is climbing. Not linearly — her moving average is jagged, a stock chart in a bad quarter — but the trend line, when she runs a regression, is positive. She runs the regression every Sunday morning. She does this at the kitchen counter of the apartment she has moved into, which is smaller than the house she kept and then sold, which is the right size for one adult who is rebuilding her baseline.

The apartment is on the sixth floor of a building in Bellevue with a real lobby. She chose it for the lobby. She spent the first week of her single life walking in and out of the lobby at different times of day to confirm that the concierge would keep calling her Dr. Menon. He did. This was not a small thing. In the marriage she had become, at some point she cannot pinpoint, Mrs. — and while she had corrected it

whenever asked, she had stopped noticing when it was not asked, and stopping noticing was the part that had cost her.

The first solo dinner is not the first dinner.

The first dinner, she cooks. She cooks an elaborate thing — a Bengali shorshe maach she has not attempted since graduate school — and she sets the table for one with a linen napkin and a glass of wine, and she sits down and she takes two bites and she starts to cry so hard she has to put her head in her hands because the fish is very good and there is no one to tell. She does not finish the fish. She wraps it. She takes the wine into the living room. She watches a documentary about an octopus. She cries again, at the octopus. She sleeps on the couch.

The spreadsheet row for that day: June 2. First solo meal. -7. The octopus cried first.

The actual first solo dinner — the one that counts — is three weeks later, at a restaurant, alone, by choice, without a book.

She sits at a two-top in the back. She orders the branzino. She orders a glass of the Vermentino. She does not bring out her phone. She does not bring out a book. She sits with her hands on the table and she looks around the restaurant like a woman doing a site survey, cataloging the room — the lighting

temperature, the ratio of couples to pairs to singletons (two other singletons, both men, both on phones), the spacing of the tables — and when the fish arrives she eats it slowly and she does not cry and she does not perform eating-alone-with-dignity. She just eats.

The spreadsheet row: June 23. Branzino. +4. First positive integer in eleven weeks.

The first date is not a date.

It is a coffee with a man her sister has set her up with, whom she has agreed to meet at the neutral hour of 11 a.m. on a Saturday because 11 a.m. is not a meal and cannot escalate. The man is a pediatric oncologist named Yusuf. He is kind-faced and slightly too tall for his chair. He orders a black coffee. She orders a black coffee. They talk for forty minutes about healthcare technology, which is a subject neither of them cares about but which is a subject they can both speak fluently, and then, in a small silence while the espresso machine shouted behind the counter, he says: my wife died three years ago. Pancreatic. I am telling you this now because I have learned that telling it later makes it sound like I hid it. I am not asking you to reciprocate. I am just telling you.

Priya looks at him.

She thinks: this is a man who has learned to engineer a disclosure. She thinks: this is a man whose

grief has made him precise. She thinks: I am going to like this man or I am going to avoid this man for the rest of my life, and I will know by the end of this coffee which one.

She says: I was married for sixteen years. He had an affair. I did not know for three. I knew, and did not act, for one. I acted six months ago. I am telling you this now because I have learned that telling it later makes it sound like I hid it.

Yusuf nods.

He does not offer sympathy. He does not flinch. He picks up his coffee, and he says: so. the branzino at Monsoon is on a Wednesday special.

She laughs.

It is her first laugh with a stranger since the papers. The laugh surprises her — it comes out higher than she expects, almost a girl's laugh, which she had thought her laugh no longer remembered how to be — and in the split-second after the laugh she thinks, very clearly: I am still in here.

On the drive home, she texts her sister: not a love. a friendship. but a friendship with a stranger is a thing. write it down.

Her sister writes back: you are the only woman alive who asks her sister to update a file.

Priya smiles.

At home, she adds the row.

June 30. Coffee with Y. +6. Laughed at a joke about branzino. I am still in here.

Her parents call that night.

Her father, on speakerphone, in the kitchen of the house she grew up in, says, carefully, without preamble: the weather here is very nice. Your mother is making the good aloo paratha.

She says: okay, appa.

Her mother says, in Malayalam, very quietly, just to her: are you eating.

She says, in Malayalam: yes, amma. Today I ate branzino.

Her mother does not know what branzino is. Her mother has never been to Italy. Her mother was married at nineteen to a man she did not choose and has been married to him for fifty-two years in a way that has required silences so dense they have become a form of architecture. Her mother does not say are you happy. Her mother does not say I am sorry this happened. Her mother says, after a pause of exactly five seconds:

is the branzino good fish. I will look it up.

Priya has to put the phone down to cry.

It is the first time her mother has asked, in any form, anything. A fish. But a fish is a question. A fish is

a hand reaching under a door.

June 30, second row: +8. Amma asked about the fish. Grief by editing has a crack in it.

Six months in, the trend line is positive.

She does not trust it yet. She is an engineer. Trend lines reverse. But she notes it. She runs the regression on Sunday morning with her good coffee and her window that faces east, and she thinks, as the sun comes up over the Cascades: I built the house. The house failed. I am building a smaller house. I am the architect and the tenant. The spreadsheet is the foundation. The branzino is a beam. My mother asking about the fish is a door.

She saves the file.

She closes the laptop.

She goes to the lobby to say good morning.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 26: THE LEAVING

* * *

WhatsApp Message *February 2024*

Meera: I left him.

* * *

Three words. After six years of “soon.” After a thousand promises and a hundred retreats. After two children, an abortion, pills on a bathroom floor, a love story that spanned an ocean, and every excuse a trapped woman could construct . She left.

Not for me. That’s the part I need you to understand. She didn’t leave for me.

* * *

She left because the second child, the boy, the one born in August 2023, changed something in her. Not the way the first child had, binding her tighter to the cage through obligation and guilt. The second one broke the cage open. Because she looked at her son

and saw the future: a boy growing up in a house where his father forced himself on his mother behind closed doors. A boy learning that what happens in the bedroom is something women endure, not enjoy. A boy becoming the thing she'd been surviving.

That future was the one thing more terrifying than leaving.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *February 2024*

Ari: Where are you?

Meera: My mother's house. With both kids.

Ari: Are you safe?

Meera: Yes.

Ari: How did you get out?

Meera: I packed two bags while he was at work. One for me, one for the kids. Called a taxi. Left before 2 PM. He doesn't get home until 6.

Ari: That's a four-hour head start.

Meera: It was enough.

* * *

A four-hour head start. Six years of marriage — rape behind closed doors, control wrapped in charm, two

children, one abortion, one suicide attempt — packed into two bags and a taxi ride that had to be completed before 6 PM.

That's what leaving looks like when you're a woman in India. Not a dramatic confrontation. Not a lawyer's office. Not a conversation. A clock. A taxi. Two bags. And the understanding that if you're still in the house when he gets home, you'll never leave again.

* * *

I waited for the call. The one where she'd say: "I left him. Now come get me." The one I'd been rehearsing in my head for six years. The flight to India. The airport arrival. The embrace. The beginning of the life we'd been planning in whispered 3 AM calls since 2018.

The call never came.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 2024*

Ari: So what happens now? With us?

Meera: ...

Ari: You left. You're free. I've been waiting for this. WE'VE been waiting for this. Since the very first night.

Meera: I know.

Ari: So?

Meera: I can't come to you, Ari.

Ari: What do you mean?

Meera: I mean I have two children. I have no job. I have no money. I have no visa. I have a husband who will fight me for custody the moment I file for divorce. I have a family that already thinks I'm a disgrace for leaving. And I have a man in America who loves me but can't be here.

Ari: I can bring you here. I've told you that.

Meera: On what visa? A tourist visa? And then what? I stay illegally? With two kids? In a country where I know nobody?

Ari: We'd figure it out.

Meera: "We'd figure it out" is not a plan. It's a prayer. And I'm done praying.

* * *

She was right. Again. She was always right about the practical architecture of impossibility. I dealt in grand gestures, flights and hotel rooms and whispered promises. She dealt in logistics, visas and custody and money and the hard mathematics of survival.

The math didn't work. It never had. I just hadn't been willing to see the equation clearly until she laid it out on a screen.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 2024 — continued*

Ari: So you left your husband but you can't be with me.

Meera: Not right now.

Ari: That sounds like "soon." And I know what "soon" means.

Meera: This is different.

Ari: How?

Meera: Because I'm not inside the cage anymore. I'm not saying "soon" to keep you. I'm saying "not right now" because I need to build something first. A life. A job. Stability. For my kids. And then. Maybe for us.

Ari: Maybe.

Meera: I can't promise you anything, Ari. I've learned what broken promises do to people. To you. To me. So I'm not promising. I'm just telling you the truth: I love you. I left. And I'm not ready.

* * *

“I love you. I left. And I’m not ready.”

Nine words that contained the entire paradox of our story. She’d done the impossible thing. Left the violent marriage, escaped the cage, taken the children, started over. And the reward for my six years of waiting was... more waiting. Indefinite this time. Without even the comfort of “soon.”

What surprised me: I didn’t explode.

The old Ari, the pre-pills Ari, the voice-note Ari, the surveillance Ari, would have raged. Would have screamed about fairness and sacrifice and years lost. Would have constructed a case for why she owed him something after everything he’d given.

But the new Ari , the one forged on the bathroom floor, the one who’d heard “that’s the first time a man has ever said that to me” . That Ari understood.

She wasn’t rejecting me. She was choosing herself. For the first time in her life. She was choosing herself, and her children, and the chance to be a person before being someone’s partner.

The man I was becoming could hold space for that. Even if it hurt.

* * *

She enrolled in a postgraduate program. With two kids under five. In her mother's two-bedroom apartment. Studying while the toddler napped and the baby screamed.

I watched from eight thousand miles away as the woman I loved rebuilt herself from nothing. No husband's money. No lover's rescue. No safety net except the one she was weaving with her own hands.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *June 2024*

Meera: I passed my first semester exams.

Ari: Of course you did.

Meera: Don't "of course" me. I studied for those exams while breastfeeding.

Ari: That's the most badass thing I've ever heard.

Meera: *[laughing emoji]* My son is my study partner. He chews on my textbooks.

Ari: I'm proud of you.

Meera: That means more than you know.

* * *

I was proud of her. Genuinely. Not the performative pride of a man who wants credit for someone else's

courage. Real pride. The kind that sits in your chest and glows without needing to be spoken.

She was becoming someone. Not the girl in the chat. Not the woman in the cage. Not the voice on the other end of a video call at 3 AM. Someone with her own shape. Her own gravity. Her own future.

That future might not include me. That was the truth I was learning to sit with.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *September 2024*

Ari: Can I ask you something?

Meera: Always.

Ari: Do you think we'll ever actually be together? In the same country? In the same room? Living a life?

Meera: I don't know.

Ari: Okay.

Meera: But I know I'll always love you. And I know what you did for me. You didn't save me . I saved myself. But you showed me I was worth saving. And that's not nothing.

Ari: It's not nothing.

Meera: It's everything. I just can't give you what you want right now.

Ari: What if what I want has changed?

Meera: What do you mean?

Ari: What if I don't need you to come here anymore? What if I just need to know you're okay? That the kids are okay? That you're building something real? What if that's enough?

Meera: ...

Meera: Is it enough?

Ari: I'm learning to let it be.

* * *

"I'm learning to let it be."

That sentence, typed in a WhatsApp chat at midnight in Seattle to a woman in a two-bedroom apartment in India, was the first honest thing I'd said in six years.

Not "I'll wait for you." Not "I'll come get you." Not "we'll figure it out." Not any of the romantic fictions I'd been spinning since 2018.

Just: "I'm learning to let it be."

* * *

The shame followed her. Even after she left. Especially after she left.

In India, a woman who leaves her husband is a woman who has failed. Not him. Her. He can be a rapist behind closed doors, the perfect husband in public. She's still the one who broke the family. She's still the one who "couldn't adjust." She's still the one the aunties whisper about at weddings and the uncles shake their heads over at temples.

Meera carried that shame like a second skin. Every phone call with a relative was a trial. Every family gathering was a sentencing. Every "when are you going back to him?" was a verdict from a court she hadn't consented to appear in.

She bore it. All of it. While studying. While mothering. While rebuilding from zero.

She bore it because the alternative, going back to a house where a man's body was a weapon he used behind a locked bedroom door, was worse than shame. Understanding that, choosing shame over violence, freedom over approval, her children's safety over society's comfort, that was the bravest thing I'd ever witnessed.

Braver than any flight I'd booked. Braver than any voice note I'd sent. Braver than any grand gesture from a man eight thousand miles away with a good salary and a theoretical willingness to help.

She saved herself. I just happened to be watching.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 27: THE FIRST APARTMENT ★

* * *

(The first month after leaving.)

The apartment has a galley kitchen and a window that faces a brick wall.

The brick is the good kind — dark red, close-up, the mortar visible, the pattern of it irregular in a way that suggests hand-laid. She pays ₹18,000 a month for the view of this wall. She pays it with her own money, from the job she has had for nine weeks, which is the job she took because it paid exactly enough and no more, and because she wanted, for a reason she could not articulate at the time and can articulate now, to do a job that did not require her to be interesting.

The job is billing coordinator at a dental clinic.

She is extremely good at it.

Her co-workers do not know she is extremely good at it, because being extremely good at a small job is invisible. She likes this. She has been visible enough for a lifetime.

Nila is three years old and she sleeps in the room next to hers, which is also the only other room, which is a closet with a window. She has made the closet into a galaxy — glow-in-the-dark stars on the ceiling, a nightlight shaped like a half-moon, a small bookshelf with seventeen books Nila has memorized. She calls it her spaceship. She tells Meera, every night, as she tucks her in: amma, the spaceship is taking off. Meera says, every night: safe travels, pilot. She closes her eyes. She sleeps.

This ritual cost her a marriage.

She does not say this to Nila. She will not say it to her, ever. But sometimes, after Nila is asleep, she stands in the doorway of the spaceship and thinks: I left a house with a yard for this closet, and I would do it again, and I would do it faster.

In the mornings she makes her own coffee.

The coffee is not good. She has not yet bought a machine. She makes it in a small pot on the stove — the way her grandmother made it, with too much sugar and not enough water, boiled hard, strained through a metal filter that stains. It tastes, every morning, like a small apology to her own body.

The first morning in the apartment, she made coffee at 5:47 a.m. and drank it standing at the window facing the brick wall. She was not tired. She was not

triumphant. She was not anything that could be described in a word. She was, she realized halfway through the cup, quiet. Not the performed quiet of a woman not waking a baby and not waking a husband. Actual quiet. The quiet of a woman who, for the first time in four years, was the only person in a room who was awake, and was therefore the only person in the room whose needs were in the room.

She cried at the sink. She had gotten used to crying at sinks. The sink was new. The crying was old. She noted the asymmetry. She rinsed the cup.

Week one, Nila asks for her father every night.

Where is appa.

She has rehearsed the answer. Appa is at his house. You will see him on Saturday. He loves you. I love you. She says it with her hand on Nila's chest, because children need to feel the truth in a palm before they will hear it in a sentence. Nila accepts it the first night. She accepts it the second night. On the third night she says, small, without looking at her mother: is it because of me.

Meera does not cry in front of her. She has a rule.

She breaks the rule.

She lies down on the floor of the spaceship next to Nila's small bed and she cries and she says, to the glow-in-the-dark ceiling: No. No, pilot. No, no, no. It is

because of me. It is because I had to learn how to be a person who could be your mother and not disappear. Do you understand? Nila does not understand. She is three. She says: okay, amma. She pats Meera's hair like Meera is the child. Meera lies there until Nila sleeps.

Then she gets up, washes her face, goes to the galley kitchen, and makes herself the second bad coffee of the day. She drinks it standing. She does not cry again.

Week two, her mother calls.

She has been expecting it.

Her mother says, in Tamil, without preamble: are you sure.

She says, in English, also without preamble: yes.

Her mother says: he was a good man.

She says: he is still a good man. I still could not live with him.

Her mother says nothing for a long time. Then she says, in Tamil: your father and I will visit next month. I will bring the good dosa batter.

She says, very softly: okay, amma.

She hangs up. She sits at the brick-wall window. She thinks: she does not approve. She is coming anyway. This is what love looks like in my family. I have been confusing disapproval with absence my whole life. She gets up. She starts a grocery list. She

writes: urad dal, rice flour, coconut oil. She will not need these. Her mother will bring batter. But she writes them anyway, because there is something in her that wants to meet her mother halfway down a street she had thought was one-way.

Week three, she does not miss him.

She notices this on a Wednesday at 8:42 p.m., standing in the kitchen rinsing a plate. She notices the not-missing the way you notice you have not sneezed in a week — only after you realize you haven't. She has not thought about Ari since Sunday. She has not thought about Vikram since Monday. She has been thinking, instead, about whether Nila needs new shoes, and about whether the dental clinic is going to extend her contract, and about whether the mint plant on the windowsill will survive the heat.

She stands with the plate in her hand and thinks: this is the first time, in ten years, that I have been a woman whose interior life is her own.

She puts the plate in the rack.

She does not cry. She does not perform. She does not narrate it into a text message or a journal entry. She puts the plate in the rack and goes to bed and sleeps seven hours, which is also new.

Week four, the phone rings.

Unknown number. She looks at it. She does not know, from the number, who it is. It could be anyone. It could be Ari. It could be a telemarketer. It could be the dental clinic asking her to come in early on Saturday. She looks at the phone ringing and for the first time in a very long time she understands, with a clean plain feeling, that she is allowed to answer it or not answer it for reasons that are hers.

She answers it.

It is a robocall.

She hangs up.

She laughs — genuinely laughs, the first real laugh of the month — because the universe has given her exactly the right test: a ringing phone, a choice, and nothing on the other end. She puts the phone down on the counter, face up, because she is not afraid of it anymore, and by Tuesday she has bought an espresso machine from the used-goods market, and she makes, for the first time since she moved in, a proper coffee.

She drinks it standing at the brick-wall window.

Nila wakes up. She pads into the kitchen in her dinosaur pajamas. She looks at Meera with the exact face her grandmother used to make. She says: amma, is the spaceship here.

Meera says: yes, pilot. The spaceship is here. We are the spaceship.

Nila nods, seriously, like a woman accepting a mission.

She eats her cereal.

Meera drinks her good coffee.

The brick wall is the color of an old heart in morning light.

She thinks: this is what I paid for. This is what it was worth.

She is right.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 28: THE EMPTY HOUSE

* * *

Moving Truck Receipt *December 15, 2023*

Service: Local move (1 bedroom apartment load)
Items: Bed frame, mattress, dresser, 6 boxes (labeled “BOOKS”), 4 boxes (labeled “KITCHEN”), 2 boxes (labeled “MISC”) From: [Redacted] Ave, Seattle, WA
To: [Redacted] St, Apt 3B, Seattle, WA

Total: \$487.00

Note from driver: “Light load. Most apartments have more.”

* * *

The driver was right. Most apartments have more. Most men who’ve been married for twelve years accumulate more than what fits on half a truck. Furniture. Photographs. The archaeological layers of a shared life. Anniversary gifts. Wedding china. The ugly lamp someone’s mother gave you that you keep because marriage is a series of ugly lamps you learn to live with.

I took almost nothing.

Not because I was being noble. Because almost nothing in that house was mine. The furniture was hers. She'd picked it. The art on the walls was hers. She'd hung it. The kitchen was hers. Organized with the precision of a woman who runs a production environment and a household on the same operating system. Even the couch — my couch, the country I'd colonized for a decade — was technically hers. She'd bought it at IKEA in 2014. She'd assembled it. I just slept on it.

So I took the bed from the guest room. My clothes. My books. A few kitchen things she'd duplicated over the years — two spatulas, a rice cooker, the cast iron skillet that neither of us used but both of us claimed. And I left.

The door closed behind me with a sound that should have been louder. Twelve years. A door. A click.

* * *

First Night — Apartment 3B

The apartment was seven hundred square feet. One bedroom, one bathroom, a kitchen that connected to a living room through an archway that the listing called “open concept” and reality called “small.” The carpet

was beige. The walls were white. The previous tenant had left a nail in the wall above where a TV must have hung, and the nail's shadow was a small dark rectangle, the ghost of someone else's life.

I sat on the guest room mattress, which was now the only mattress, which was on the floor because the bed frame hadn't been assembled yet, and I looked at the apartment and I thought: this is what forty looks like.

Not forty with a wife and a house and the infrastructure of a life that other people could see and say "he's doing well." Forty in an apartment with beige carpet and a nail in the wall and six boxes of books I hadn't read since my twenties but couldn't bring myself to donate because they were the only things in the apartment that had history.

* * *

The silence was different.

I need to explain this because people think silence is silence. It's not. There are species of silence, and I'd lived in most of them.

The silence of the marriage: two people in the same house, not speaking. The hum of the refrigerator filling the space where conversation should be. Priya in the

bedroom, me on the couch, the TV between us doing the work of a mediator. That silence was heavy. Pressurized. The silence of a submarine. Two people breathing the same recycled air, knowing the hull is holding, knowing eventually it won't.

The silence of Meera's ghosting: the silence of absence. No messages. No calls. The phone a black mirror reflecting nothing back. That silence was a vacuum. It pulled at you. It made you lean toward the phone, check the screen, tap the app, scroll for signs of life. Active silence. Hungry silence.

This silence — the apartment silence — was different from both. It wasn't the silence of someone refusing to speak. It wasn't the silence of someone who'd disappeared. It was the silence of nobody being there at all. No one to refuse. No one to disappear. Just rooms and air and beige carpet and the distant sound of the upstairs neighbor's TV through the ceiling.

Empty silence. And empty silence, it turns out, is the one you can actually breathe in.

* * *

Grocery Store Receipt — QFC, Seattle *December 16, 2023*

Eggs (6-pack) Bread (wheat) Butter Milk (whole,
half gallon) Coffee (ground, medium roast) Rice (5 lb
bag) Sambar powder Salt Pepper Dish soap Paper
towels 1 pan (nonstick, 10-inch)

Total: \$47.83

* * *

I'd always bought groceries alone. In twelve years of marriage, that had somehow become mine — the Costco runs, the lists on the fridge, the bulk buying. Everything plural because marriage demands plural, even when only one person is doing it.

But this was different. This was singular without the pretense of plural.

The singular was disorienting. One pan. A six-pack of eggs instead of a dozen. A half gallon of milk because a full gallon would expire before I could drink it. A five-pound bag of rice because the ten-pound bag was what we'd always bought and the "we" no longer existed and ten pounds of rice for one man is an act of insane optimism.

I stood in the rice aisle for four minutes. Holding a five-pound bag. Doing the math. Five pounds of rice. One cup per meal. Maybe three meals a week with rice. Five pounds would last a month. A month of meals

alone. A month of one plate on a counter instead of two plates on a table.

The math was simple. The math was unbearable.

I bought the five-pound bag. And a pan. And the smallest container of sambar powder they had, because I was going to learn to make sambar, because my mother had made sambar and Priya had made sambar and Meera had made sambar and every woman in my life had made sambar and I had never made sambar and I was forty years old and it was time.

* * *

First Saturday

* * *

iPhone Screen Time Report *Saturday, December 17, 2023*

Daily Total: 1h 12m (↓ 84% from weekly average)
WhatsApp: 0m TikTok: 0m Safari: 22m (searches: “IKEA MALM bed frame missing bolt substitute,” “how to make sambar,” “is it normal to cry assembling furniture”) Phone app: 0m Pickups: 7

* * *

Weather App — Seattle, WA *December 17, 2023*

47°F. Overcast. 100% chance of rain. Sunrise: 7:54 AM
Sunset: 4:18 PM

8 hours and 24 minutes of daylight. Enough to build a bed frame and ruin some eggs.

* * *

7 AM: Made coffee. Bad coffee. Too much water. Not enough grounds. The coffee of a man who's never paid attention to how coffee works because someone else always made it.

8 AM: Assembled the bed frame. Took two hours because the instructions were in Swedish and one of the bolts was missing and I used a fork as a substitute tool because I didn't own tools. The bed frame was crooked. The mattress sat on it like a hat on a drunk man. Functional. Ugly. Mine.

10 AM: Made eggs. Scrambled. Too dry. No technique. I'd watched Meera crack eggs in a hotel kitchenette and make them perfect with minibar butter, and I couldn't replicate it in my own kitchen with actual butter and a brand-new pan.

11 AM: Sat on the crooked bed and stared at the wall.

The wall was white. Not the wall Priya faced. A different wall in a different room in a different life. But the act of staring at a wall is the same regardless of which wall it is. You sit. You look at nothing. You let the thoughts come.

I was lonely. Not new-lonely. Old-lonely. The kind I'd been medicating with a woman in a phone and a TikTok audience and anger and suspicion and control. The architecture had finally collapsed. Here I was. Alone with myself. In a seven-hundred-square-foot apartment that smelled like bad coffee and uncooked sambar powder.

* * *

First Sambar Attempt

I called my mother.

Not for comfort. For instructions. She was seventy-two and lived in Pondicherry and had been making sambar since before I was born and would be making sambar after I was gone. Sambar was her mother tongue. More fluent than Tamil. More reliable than love.

“Amma. How do you make sambar?”

Silence. The specific silence of a Tamil mother processing the fact that her forty-year-old son, who

has been eating sambar for four decades, does not know how to make sambar.

“You don’t know how to make sambar?”

“I never learned.”

“What was your wife doing?”

“Making sambar.”

“And now?”

“She’s not here anymore.”

Another silence. Longer. The kind where a mother does the math and arrives at the answer without being told. She didn’t ask about the divorce. She didn’t ask about Priya. She did what Tamil mothers do when their children are in pain: she gave instructions.

“Toor dal. One cup. Wash it three times. Not two. Three. Pressure cooker, four whistles. While the dal cooks, heat oil in a pan. Mustard seeds first. When they pop, curry leaves. Then onion. Then tomato. Then sambar powder. You have sambar powder?”

“Yes.”

“Good brand?”

“I don’t know. It was the only one they had.”

“What brand?”

“MTR.”

“Acceptable. Two tablespoons. Add tamarind water. How do you make tamarind water?”

“I don’t know.”

“Aiyoo.”

She walked me through it. Twenty-five minutes of instruction, delivered with the patience of a woman who had waited forty years for this phone call and the exasperation of a woman who couldn't believe it had taken this long.

The sambar was terrible. Watery. Under-salted. The dal was overcooked — five whistles instead of four because I'd been on the phone and lost count. The tamarind was too sour. The whole thing tasted like a mistake with good intentions.

I ate it with rice. Sitting on the kitchen floor because I didn't have a table yet. Back against the cabinet. Bowl in my lap. Eating bad sambar with a spoon because I was too tired to eat with my hands and too stubborn to order food.

It was the best meal I'd had in months.

Not because it was good. Because I'd made it. Because my mother's voice had guided my hands. Because the kitchen smelled like something I'd produced, not something I'd been served. Because for the first time in my adult life, I was feeding myself. Literally. Metaphorically. A man sitting on a kitchen floor eating his own terrible sambar, and nobody was watching, and nobody was judging, and the silence was empty, and the empty silence was okay.

* * *

WhatsApp — Drafts (never sent) *December 2023*

To Meera: “I made sambar today. You would have laughed. It tasted like a puddle with ambition.”

* * *

I didn’t send it. Not because it wasn’t true. Because it was a truth that belonged to the man I was becoming, not the man she had known. The man she knew reached for his phone when the silence got loud. The man I was becoming sat on a kitchen floor and let the silence be.

* * *

That night I lay on the crooked bed in the dark apartment and listened to the upstairs neighbor’s TV and the traffic outside and the refrigerator humming in the kitchen and I thought:

This is what zero feels like.

Not rock bottom. Not the bathroom floor. Not the couch. Zero. The starting point. The place you stand when you’ve subtracted everything that wasn’t yours — the marriage, the affair, the performing, the needing — and you’re left with just a man in a room with bad

sambar on his breath and a crooked bed and a five-pound bag of rice and the quiet.

Zero is not empty. Zero is the space where something new can be built.

I didn't know what I was building yet. I just knew I was done borrowing other people's structures and calling them home.

I fell asleep at 10 PM. The earliest I'd slept in years. No phone. No calls. No screen. Just dark and quiet and a body that had finally stopped running.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 29: THE TRUTH

* * *

Search History — Safari, Private Mode

December 2024

- “how to know if someone lied to you for years”
- “can you love someone who deceived you”
- “signs of codependent relationship”
- “attachment theory anxious avoidant trap”
- “is marital rape legal in India”
- “how long does it take to forgive someone”
- “how long does it take to forgive yourself”

* * *

I spent a year excavating.

Not her. She’d told me everything by then, in pieces, in confessions extracted and volunteered, in the slow unbandaging of a wound she’d been covering since 2018. There was nothing left to discover about Meera. The truth was on the table, ugly and complete.

I was excavating myself.

* * *

Here is the full truth. All of it. Laid out like evidence in a case where both parties are guilty and both parties are victims and the jury is just one man sitting in a house in Seattle trying to understand how he got here.

Truth #1: She lied about the baby.

She let me believe the child was mine for four years. She hadn't been certain it was mine. She'd been with her husband in the same window. She let me believe because belief was the glue. My belief in the baby was what kept me calling, kept me flying, kept me present. Without it, she feared I'd calculate the odds and walk away. She was probably right.

Was it manipulation? Yes. Was it survival? Also yes. Can something be both? I've spent a year learning that the answer is almost always yes.

Truth #2: The sex with her husband wasn't always force.

This was the hardest one. The one I kept circling back to at 3 AM. The one that made me nauseous and then made me furious and then made me sad and then made me nauseous again.

He raped her. That is true. Repeatedly. Violently. In a country where marital rape isn't a crime and a

wife's body is considered community property. That truth doesn't change.

But there were also times, she admitted this finally and completely, when she didn't resist. When she lay there and let it happen. When the energy required to fight was more than the energy required to endure. And there may have been times . She never said this explicitly, but the silence around the question was its own answer . When it wasn't endurance at all.

She lived with him. Shared a bed. Raised a child. The human body doesn't maintain permanent resistance to proximity. That's not a moral judgment. It's biology. Expecting her to have been a fortress for six years, impenetrable, untouched, mine alone, was expecting her to be something no human being can be.

But I expected it anyway. Because I needed her to be only mine. And that need, that desperate consuming possessive need, was as much a cage as anything her husband built.

Truth #3: I was never going to save her.

Six years of "I'll bring you here." "I'll support you." "Just leave and I'll take care of everything." Grand promises from a man on the other side of the planet with a credit card and a theoretical plan.

But I never filed immigration paperwork. Never consulted a lawyer. Never researched visa options for a

woman with two children and no divorce. Never created an actual, executable plan for the rescue I kept promising.

Because the promise was enough. For both of us. The promise was the thing that kept the story alive. The romantic fiction that one day, somehow, the logistics would resolve themselves and love would conquer geography and law and culture and economics.

It never would have. And I think I always knew that. The promise wasn't a plan. It was a sedative.

Truth #4: I used her too.

She used me as an escape. I used her as a resurrection. My marriage was dead. My self-worth was measured in TikTok Live viewers. Meera made me visible again. I needed that so badly I was willing to overlook every inconsistency — the math, the “soons,” the baby, the sex. Because the alternative was returning to the silence. The dead couch. The house where I was furniture.

Meera was my oxygen. When your lungs are burning, you don't question where the air is coming from.

Truth #5: The love was real.

After all of it — the lies, the pills, the voice note, the years of half-truths — the love was real. Not perfectly.

Not honestly. Not sustainably. But with the desperate intensity of two people who found each other in the dark and held on too tight because letting go meant going back to the dark alone.

The love was real. Everything built on top of it was complicated. But the foundation was real.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App January 2025

"I've been assembling the truth like a mosaic. Each piece ugly on its own. But when you step back far enough, the picture isn't ugly. It's human."

"She lied to me. I lied to Priya. She couldn't leave him. I couldn't leave her. She used me as escape. I used her as resurrection. She feared my abandonment. I feared her disappearance. She said 'soon.' I said 'I'll save you.' Neither of us delivered."

"Two imperfect people doing imperfect things inside an impossible situation. That's not a tragedy. That's just... life."

"The tragedy would be learning nothing from it."

* * *

I started reading. Not self-help. I've always hated the genre, how it packages complex pain into bullet points and action items. I read psychology. Attachment theory. Codependency. The literature on anxious-avoidant dynamics: how a person terrified of abandonment and a person terrified of engulfment find each other with the precision of heat-seeking missiles and then spend years confirming each other's worst fears.

That was us. I was the anxious one. Monitoring, pursuing, demanding reassurance. She was the avoidant one. Retreating, promising, maintaining distance. We'd been locked in that dance for half a decade, each step perfectly choreographed to maximize pain.

Understanding this didn't erase the pain. But it relocated it. Moved it from the category of "she betrayed me" to the category of "we were two wounded people enacting our wounds on each other."

That relocation changed everything.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *February 2025*

Ari: I want to tell you something. And I don't want you to apologize or explain. I just want you to hear it.

Meera: Okay.

Ari: I forgive you. For the baby. For the lies. For all of it.

Meera: ...

Ari: And I'm sorry. For the voice note. For the surveillance. For all of it.

Meera: Ari...

Ari: You don't have to say anything.

Meera: I don't deserve you.

Ari: We both deserved better than what we did to each other.

* * *

Forgiveness isn't a moment. I know that now. It's not a conversation or a WhatsApp message or a journal entry. It's a practice. A daily decision to put the knife down. Some days I put it down and pick it up again by noon. Some days I forget it exists entirely. Some days I hold it so tight my knuckles go white and I have to remind myself, again, that the person I'm cutting is myself.

But the direction is clear. The trajectory is toward release.

Not release of her. I'll never fully release her. She's in the architecture of who I am now, woven into the

walls, embedded in the foundation. You don't spend six years loving someone across an ocean and walk away without carrying the geography in your bones.

Release of the story I told myself about her. The villain story. The victim story. The "she used me" story. The "I deserved better" story.

Those stories were true. And they were incomplete. Incomplete truths are a trap. They give you just enough evidence to justify your pain without ever asking you to examine your role in creating it.

The full truth, the ugly, messy, both-guilty, both-innocent, impossibly human truth, is the only one worth carrying.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App March 2025

"Five truths. She lied. I raged. She used me. I used her. And the love was real."

"Two broken people who broke each other further and still, somehow, ended up more whole than they started."

"That has to be enough. Because it is."

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 30: FORTY

* * *

iPhone Calendar *December 27, 2026*

All-day event: 🎂 No other entries.

* * *

I turned forty alone.

Not alone as in nobody knew. People knew. My mother called at 6 AM Indian time, which was 4:30 PM Seattle time the day before, because she refuses to learn time zones and insists that calling on the actual day in India counts regardless of what day it is in America. “Happy birthday, kanna. Did you eat?” That’s how Tamil mothers say I love you. Not the words. The food check.

My TikTok regulars sent gifts during the Live I didn’t do. Thirty-seven notifications from people I’d never met in person, sending pixelated roses and animated cakes through a screen. Kind. Meaningless. The currency of parasocial love.

Meera texted at midnight her time. 10:30 AM mine.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *December 27, 2026*

Meera: Happy birthday, Ari. 🎂

Ari: Thank you.

Meera: How are you spending it?

Ari: Alone. By choice.

Meera: That's new.

Ari: That's the point.

* * *

Priya texted nothing. I noticed. I noticed that I noticed. And then I noticed that the noticing didn't hurt.

A year ago, the absence of a birthday text from my wife — ex-wife — would have been a wound I'd pick at for days. Evidence of erasure. Proof that twelve years meant nothing. Fuel for the narrative I'd built about being invisible, unseen, unvalued.

Now it was just a fact. She didn't text. The sun was out. The coffee was better than last month's. Facts. All equal. All survivable.

* * *

Birthday Dinner — Party of One

I made chicken biryani.

Not the hotel biryani from India. Not Meera's mother's biryani. Not the biryani from any restaurant or any memory or any night spent in a hotel room with white sheets. My biryani. The one I'd been practicing for six months, failing at for five of them, and finally getting right — or close enough to right — in the sixth.

The rice was separate. Each grain. That had taken three attempts to learn. The chicken was tender. The masala was layered — onion fried dark, tomato cooked down, spices bloomed in oil until the kitchen smelled like my mother's kitchen, like every Tamil kitchen, like the universal frequency of home.

I set one plate on the table. The table I'd bought in January from a thrift store. Solid wood. Scratched. Other people's dinners had lived on this surface. Other dinners would follow. I didn't mind the scratches. They were proof that a table is meant to be used, not preserved.

One plate. One glass of wine. Red. Nothing expensive. A celebration that didn't need an audience.

I sat down and ate.

No phone on the table. No TV in the background. No music. Just the sound of a fork against a plate and the taste of biryani that I'd made with my own hands on my fortieth birthday in an apartment where nobody was waiting and nobody was watching and nobody was

asking me to be anything other than a man eating dinner.

The biryani was good. Not great. The saffron was slightly too strong. The fried onions could have been darker. But it was mine. Every grain of rice, every piece of chicken, every mistake and adjustment. Mine.

* * *

After dinner, I washed the plate. The glass. The pot. The pan. The cutting board. Everything. By hand. Not because the dishwasher was broken. Because there's something about washing your own dishes on your birthday that feels like a statement. I fed myself. I cleaned up after myself. The cycle is complete. No one owes me anything. I owe no one anything.

I poured a second glass of wine. Took it to the window.

Seattle in December is dark by 4:30. By the time I stood at the window with my wine, the city was lit up. Not Christmas-lit. Just city-lit. Office buildings. Street lamps. The headlights on I-5 making a slow river of white and red. And beyond the city, if you leaned right and squinted, the mountains. Rainier on clear days. Tonight was half-clear. The mountain was a shadow. A

suggestion of something massive and permanent behind the clouds.

I stood at the window and looked at the mountains and thought about the man I was at thirty-two.

* * *

The man I was at thirty-two:

Married. Miserable. Sleeping on a couch. Performing on TikTok because three hundred strangers saying his name felt more real than the silence in his own house. About to meet a girl in a chat who would rearrange his molecular structure. About to fall in love with a woman he couldn't have, in a country he'd left, through a phone that would become his whole world.

The man I was at thirty-two would not recognize the man standing at this window.

Not because the window man is better. He's not. He's just different. The thirty-two-year-old needed to be seen. Needed an audience. Needed a woman's voice in his ear to confirm he existed. The forty-year-old stands at a window alone and knows he exists because the biryani was good and the wine is acceptable and the mountains are there whether anyone sees them or not.

* * *

Journal Entry — iPhone Notes App *December 27, 2026, 11:47 PM*

“Forty.”

“My mother called. Meera texted. Priya didn’t. My TikTok audience sent digital roses. I made biryani and drank wine and looked at a mountain.”

“The man I was at thirty-two would not recognize the man I am at forty. And that’s the whole point.”

“At thirty-two, I was hungry. For love, for touch, for validation, for someone to tell me I was worth crossing an ocean for. I found all of it. In a woman. In a phone. In hotel rooms and midnight calls and the word ‘soon’ repeated until it lost all meaning.”

“At forty, I’m full. Not because I got what I wanted. Because I stopped wanting it from other people.”

“I still love Meera. I’ll always love Meera. But the love is different now. It doesn’t pull. It doesn’t ache. It doesn’t wake me up at 2 AM to check if she’s online. It sits in my chest like a fact. Like the mountains. Present. Massive. Not going anywhere. Not demanding anything.”

“I still respect Priya. I failed her. I failed her in ways I’m still counting. She deserved a husband who

was present, and I gave her a man who was on a phone. That's my weight to carry. Not as punishment. As education."

"Today I turned forty. Alone. In an apartment with a scratched table and a crooked bed and sambar powder in the cabinet and a view of mountains I can only see when I lean right."

"It's enough. It's more than enough. It's abundance."

* * *

I finished the wine. Washed the glass. Turned off the lights. Went to bed.

The bed wasn't crooked anymore. I'd fixed it in February. Bought a real wrench. Tightened the bolts. Level now. Solid. A bed a man sleeps well in because he assembled it himself and fixed it himself and lies in it knowing that the structure holding him up is his own work.

I closed my eyes.

Forty. Alone. Full.

The mountains were still there in the dark. I couldn't see them. I didn't need to.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 31: THE FRIEND

* * *

(Coffee shop. A Tuesday.)

Sameer shows up on a Tuesday.

Ari is in the corner of the café in Fremont where he has been writing — or not writing, which is the honest word — for three weeks. The corner has a brick wall behind it and a bad table and a window he does not look out of. He has been drinking a black coffee for four hours. The black coffee has become a dark smear on the inside of the cup. A different man, a younger man, would have ordered a second coffee to justify the table. Ari has stopped pretending to justify things.

Sameer walks in without warning.

He has a backpack on one shoulder and a face that says he has just come from a flight. He has, in fact, just come from a flight. He does not announce this. He looks at Ari, sitting at the corner table with his dark cup, and he walks over, and he puts the backpack down on the opposite chair like he has been walking toward this chair for six hours, and he says:

you look like shit. I'm getting you a real drink. what are you having.

Ari blinks.

He says: it's 2 p.m.

Sameer says: I know what time it is. I asked what you're having.

Ari says, after a second: mint tea.

Sameer goes to the counter.

Ari watches him go. Sameer has been Ari's friend since the two of them were seventeen years old in an engineering prep class in Chennai, where Sameer had cheated off Ari's trigonometry and Ari had let him. Sameer went on to become a software engineer. Sameer is now a product manager at a company Ari cannot remember the name of. Sameer has a wife and a dog and no children and a small apartment in Jackson Heights that he is extremely proud of. Sameer has not flown to Seattle today to see Ari. He has, Ari will later learn, flown from New York to attend an old college friend's baby's first birthday in Syosset, and is now on his way back. He is here, in this café, in the middle of his layover, because he is the kind of man who uses a layover to check on a friend.

Ari has not told Sameer anything.

Ari has not told Sameer about Meera. Ari has not told Sameer about Priya. Ari has not told Sameer that

he has been, for three weeks, in the corner of a café in Fremont, not writing. Ari has spoken to Sameer twice in six months. The last time was a WhatsApp call on Sameer's birthday in which Ari had sung an off-key happy birthday and then made a joke about Sameer's hairline and then signed off and then sat in the dark for a while.

Sameer comes back with two mint teas.

Sameer sits.

Sameer says, not looking at Ari, stirring his tea: my dad had a stroke last month. he's fine. it was a baby stroke. he's doing PT. my mom is — you know. being my mom. anyway. also my work is fine. also Shilpa is pregnant, eight weeks, we're not telling anyone, don't tell anyone. that's the news from me.

Ari says: I —

Sameer says: I'm not asking for a news update, ya. I'm making conversation.

He blows on his tea.

He says: how's the mint.

This is a thing Sameer has been doing, Ari slowly realizes, for twenty years.

Sameer has been showing up. Not with questions, because Ari does not answer questions — Ari turns questions into performances, which Sameer figured out at nineteen and has been gently refusing to feed

ever since — but with news. Sameer shows up with news. Sameer fills the air first. Sameer empties his own pockets so that Ari, if he wants to, can put something down. Most of the time Ari does not put anything down. Most of the time Ari stays empty-handed and Sameer does not complain.

Ari has never noticed this before.

Ari has, in fact, spent much of the last decade vaguely condescending to Sameer in his own mind. Sameer is a product manager in Jackson Heights. Sameer does not read books. Sameer's WhatsApp photo is his dog. Sameer has the kind of life, Ari has sometimes told himself, that is available to people who have not been blessed and cursed by having an interior.

In the corner of a café in Fremont, over a mint tea he did not order, Ari realizes, with a shame so clean it is almost a relief, that Sameer has had an interior the entire time. Sameer has simply never required Ari to attend to it in order to prove that he was a good friend. Sameer has loved Ari for twenty years in the way of a man who does not ask to be loved back in an equivalent coin. Sameer has been showing up.

Ari has been mythologizing his own hunger for twenty years while a man flew across countries during layovers to hand him mint tea.

He does not say any of this out loud.

He would ruin it if he said it out loud.

He says: the mint is good.

Sameer says: the mint is fine. the mint is a mint. so.
what are we doing about your face.

They do not do anything about his face.

They sit for two hours. Sameer tells Ari, in small unsorted doses, about his father's stroke — which was not, actually, a baby stroke, but which Sameer will describe as one until six months from now in a different conversation — about the PT schedule, about the way his mother has started cooking aggressively, about the fact that his wife's pregnancy has so far manifested as a strong dislike for the smell of the refrigerator. Ari listens. Ari, for the first time in a long time, listens without preparing a response. He lets Sameer's news sit in the air and take up the oxygen Ari would otherwise have been converting into his own performance.

Halfway through, Sameer looks up and says, as if answering a question no one has asked:

I didn't come here to ask you about your shit, ya. I came because Karthik's kid's first birthday is in Syosset and my layover is six hours and if I go sit in SEA-TAC I will eat that entire Shake Shack, and you

live eighteen minutes from the airport, and your mom called my mom.

Ari says: my mom called your mom.

Sameer says: aunty called amma. yes.

Ari says, slowly: what did she say.

Sameer says: she said — and I'm quoting — she said: Meera called. Meera's fine. Ari — not fine. See him.

Ari puts the mint tea down.

It takes him four seconds to understand.

His mother called Sameer's mother because his mother, at seventy-one, across an ocean, in a kitchen in Chennai with a tap that drips when she does not tighten it properly, has been keeping track of him. His mother does not text him about his feelings because she has never learned how to text him about his feelings. His mother made a phone call to another mother in another kitchen and said the three words — Ari — not fine — and that phone call has become a mint tea at a café in Fremont on a Tuesday at 2 p.m.

Ari had thought he was alone.

Ari was never alone.

Ari was simply not looking at the network that had been holding him up the entire time — the network of aunties who call each other about sons, the network of

a friend who takes a layover, the network of a mint tea bought without being asked for.

He does not cry at the table. He is not quite ready to cry at tables in front of Sameer. He will cry in the bathroom in eleven minutes, briefly, in the way men of his generation cry — shoulders tight, jaw clenched, breath like he is lifting something heavy — and he will come back to the table and he will not explain and Sameer will not ask. Sameer will just nudge the second mint tea across the table, because Sameer has bought a second round while Ari was in the bathroom, and Sameer will say:

mint tea doesn't fix shit. but it also doesn't break shit. medium-low impact beverage. we can build on it.

Ari will laugh.

It will be the first real laugh in thirty days.

It will be a laugh that does not come from a place he has been mining for performance. It will come from a place that was already filled, by a phone call between two mothers, by a layover, by a friend who knew enough to not ask the question he was here to answer.

When Sameer leaves — at 4:37 p.m., to get to Syosset for the birthday cake — he hugs Ari at the door. The hug is a real hug. Indian men of their generation have learned, slowly, painfully, to give real hugs. It still takes two beats longer than it should to

find the arm positions. They find them. Sameer slaps Ari once on the back, lightly. He says, into Ari's shoulder, muffled:

call your mother.

Ari says: yeah.

Sameer says: I mean tonight, ya.

Ari says: yeah.

Sameer leaves.

Ari stands on the sidewalk for a while.

Then he goes home.

Then he calls his mother.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 32: THE KING

* * *

Screen Time Report — Ari's iPhone *January 2027*

Daily average: 2 hrs 14 min Most used: Spotify (47 min), Notes (31 min), Camera (18 min) WhatsApp: 12 min TikTok: 0 min

Down 71% from January 2021

* * *

I deleted TikTok on a Thursday.

Not dramatically. Not as a statement. The way you delete an app that you haven't opened in three weeks and that's taking up storage. A swipe. A confirmation. Gone. The app that had introduced me to three hundred strangers and one woman and an entire alternate life, removed in two seconds with the same gesture I'd use to delete a weather widget.

I didn't feel anything. That was the strangest part. Two years ago, deleting TikTok would have felt like amputation. Cutting off the part of myself that was

loved, that performed, that existed in the only way I knew how — through an audience. @ari_live99, the man who played Tamil songs and made people feel seen, was the version of me I liked most. The real Ari — the couch Ari, the silent marriage Ari, the 2 AM phone call Ari — was the version I was running from.

Now there was only one version. And he didn't need an app to exist.

* * *

It didn't happen on a Thursday. The deletion was a Thursday. The transformation was slower. A series of small moments over fourteen months that, stacked together, formed a shape I didn't recognize until I stepped back far enough to see it.

* * *

Moment 1: The First Time I Didn't Check

February 2025. Three months after the divorce. Two months in the apartment. I woke up at 6 AM and reached for my phone and — stopped.

Not a dramatic stop. My hand was halfway to the nightstand and it just... paused. Like the signal between my brain and my fingers had been

interrupted. The routine was: wake, reach, check WhatsApp, check TikTok, check if Meera was online. That had been the sequence for six years. Every morning. Before coffee. Before consciousness fully loaded.

My hand paused. And in the pause, a thought:
What if I don't?

What if I don't check. What if I make coffee first. What if I let whatever is on that screen wait until I've had a cup of something warm and looked out the window and confirmed that the world exists independent of what anyone has sent me.

I made coffee. Stood at the window. The mountains were out. Rainier, fully visible, snow-capped, lit pink by the early sun. I stood there for eight minutes. No phone. Just coffee and a mountain and a silence that wasn't waiting to be filled.

I checked the phone at 6:23. No messages. Nothing had happened. The world had continued to exist without my surveillance.

But I had existed for twenty-three minutes without checking. And that was new.

* * *

Moment 2: The First Boundary

April 2025. Meera called at midnight. I was in bed. The old me would have answered before the second ring. The old me would have stayed on the phone for four hours and gone to work on two hours of sleep and told himself the exhaustion was worth it because her voice was oxygen.

The phone rang. I looked at it. Her name. Her photo. The same photo from years ago — laughing, mid-sentence, the happiest version of her.

I pressed decline.

Then I texted: “Saw your call. Can we talk tomorrow? I’m trying to sleep by 11 these days.”

She replied: “Of course. Sorry for calling late.”

That was it. No drama. No guilt. No three-hour conversation about why I didn’t answer. A thirty-second exchange that would have been impossible two years ago.

It didn’t feel like declining oxygen. It felt like choosing sleep.

* * *

Moment 3: The Mirror

July 2025. I was brushing my teeth. Looking at my face. The usual face. Forehead lines. Jaw that was sharper than it used to be — I’d been eating less,

moving more, not because of a fitness plan but because cooking for one means smaller portions and walking is free.

I looked at my face and I thought: *I respect this person.*

Not “I love this person.” Not “I’m proud of this person.” Respect. The kind you give someone who’s made mistakes and stopped making excuses for them.

* * *

Moment 4: The Voice Note He Didn’t Send

December 2026. Two years in the apartment. He recorded a voice note. Not for Meera. Not for Priya. For himself.

* * *

Voice Note — Self *December 15, 2026, 9:22 PM*

Duration: 1:14

“You were right about the facts. And you were the worst — okay, start over.”

[pause]

“Both things are true. You were right and you were the worst version of yourself. In the same breath. That’s — yeah.”

[long exhale]

“I’m not that man anymore. Not because I — not because I decided. Because I did the work. The boring work. Sitting alone. Not reaching for —”

[pause]

“The silence fills itself now. That’s the thing. It actually fills itself.”

* * *

He never sent it. It lived in his voice memos between a grocery list and a song idea he’d hummed in the shower. An unremarkable file.

But he listened to it sometimes. Late at night. When the old hunger whispered. He’d play it and hear his own voice — calm, tired, honest — and remember that the man speaking had been earned.

* * *

Screen Time Report — Ari’s iPhone *February 2027*

Daily average: 1 hr 48 min Most used: Spotify (42 min), Camera (22 min), Notes (19 min) WhatsApp: 8 min TikTok: Not installed Social media total: 0 min

* * *

Zero minutes of social media. Not as deprivation. As completion. The man who'd built a life on being seen had become a man who didn't need to be seen. The man who'd performed for three hundred strangers every night had stopped performing. Not because the performance wasn't good. Because it wasn't necessary.

* * *

I'm writing this in the apartment. The same apartment. I've been here three years now. The carpet is still beige. The nail is still in the wall. I put a photo over it — not of Meera, not of Priya, not of any woman. A photo of Rainier I took on a morning walk. The mountain in winter. Clear sky. Pink light.

The bed is level. The table is scratched. The sambar is good — not my mother's good, but close. Close enough that she called last week and said "acceptable" and that's the highest compliment a Tamil mother gives.

I'm alone. I'm full. I'm forty and I know what that means now.

The mountains are out tonight. Rainier in moonlight. Silver and impossible and permanent.

I look at them.

I don't reach for my phone.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 33: ABUNDANCE

* * *

WhatsApp Message — Ari to Meera *April 2027*

Ari: I wrote a book about us.

Meera: What?

Ari: A novel. Our story. Seven years of it.

Meera: You're joking.

Ari: When have I ever joked about you?

Meera: ...Are the names real?

Ari: No. Everything's changed. But you'll know.

When you read it, you'll know every word.

Meera: Should I be scared?

Ari: No. You should be proud. We survived something. And I turned it into art.

Meera: Are we your material, Ari?

* * *

I stared at that message for a long time. Longer than I want to admit. Because the honest answer is: yes. You are. You always were. Every fight, every orgasm, every silence, every lie — I was already narrating it while it

was happening. Writing the sentence while living the feeling. That's the ugliest truth in this book, and I almost left it out.

* * *

Ari: Yes. And I'm sorry for that.

Meera: Don't be sorry. Just don't pretend the book is for me. It's for you. It was always for you.

Ari: ...Yeah.

Meera: That's okay. Write it. Just know what it is.

* * *

I'm writing this last chapter from a different house.

Same city. Same rain. Same Pacific Northwest grey that would depress anyone who didn't understand that grey is just every color being held at once. But a different house. A different life. A different man sitting in a different chair, looking at the same mountains through a different window.

Priya and I separated. Quietly. The way our marriage had lived: without drama, without explosion, without the cinematic confrontation that would make a better chapter. We sat at a kitchen table and said the words we'd both been carrying for years, and the

words were simple: this isn't working. It hasn't been working. We both deserve more.

She didn't cry. I didn't cry. We'd used up our tears on other people.

* * *

Text Messages — Ari to Priya 2026

Ari: I'm sorry. For everything I didn't give you. For everything I gave someone else.

Priya: I know.

Ari: You deserved a husband who was present. I wasn't.

Priya: No. You weren't.

Ari: I can't undo it. But I can stop pretending it didn't happen.

Priya: That's all I ever wanted. For you to stop pretending.

* * *

She knew. Of course she knew. Not the details . Not India, not the calls, not the baby that wasn't mine, not the panties in a DHL envelope. But the absence. The man-shaped hole in the marriage where a husband should have been. She'd lived inside that hole for

years, quietly, with a dignity I didn't deserve and a patience I'll never fully understand.

Priya is not the villain of this story. She never was. She was the person I hurt most by loving someone else, and she bore that hurt without ever making it my problem. That's not coldness. That's not distance. Love so quiet it's almost invisible, the love of a woman who stayed not because she was trapped but because she hoped, year after year, that the man she married would come back.

He didn't. And eventually, she stopped waiting too.

* * *

I live alone now. For the first time in my adult life.

No wife in the next room. No lover on the phone. No TikTok Live audience filling the silence with hearts and virtual roses. Just me. In a space I've chosen. With furniture I've picked and meals I've cooked and mornings that belong to nobody else.

It's terrifying. And it's the first honest thing I've ever done.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App *January 2027*

“I’m forty. How the hell am I forty?”

“Here’s what I know at forty that I didn’t know at thirty-two when a girl in a TikTok chat changed my life:”

* * *

Meera and I still talk.

Not every day. Not the four-hour calls of 2021 or the frantic WhatsApp threads of 2019. We talk the way two people talk who’ve been through a war together and come out on opposite sides of an ocean, scarred but standing.

She asks about my day. I ask about the kids. She sends photos of her son chewing on textbooks. I send photos of the mountains from my new window. We laugh about things that used to make us scream. We’re gentle with each other in ways we never were when we were trying to be everything to each other.

She’s studying. She’s co-parenting. She left her husband. Really left, not “soon” left. She’s building a life with her own hands in a country that told her she should have stayed and endured. She’s doing it without me.

That used to be the tragedy. Now it’s the point.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 2027*

Meera: Do you ever think about the hotel room?

Ari: Which one?

Meera: Both of them. All of it. The first time you touched me. The way I cried.

Ari: Every day.

Meera: Me too. Not with sadness anymore. With...
I don't know the word.

Ari: Gratitude?

Meera: Maybe. Something like that. Like looking at a scar and being glad it happened because it means you survived something.

Ari: That's a good way to put it.

Meera: I learned it from you. The writing thing.
Finding words for feelings.

Ari: You always had the feelings. I just helped with the subtitles.

Meera: *[laughing emoji]* Subtitles. You're ridiculous.

Ari: You love it.

Meera: I do. I always did.

* * *

I don't need her anymore. That's the difference.

Not "I don't love her." I love her. I'll love her until the last synapse in my brain stops firing and probably for a few seconds after that. She's in the walls. She's in the architecture. She's the woman who taught me that I could feel things I'd forgotten I was capable of feeling.

But I don't NEED her. Not the way I needed her in 2018, when her attention was oxygen and her absence was suffocation. Not the way I needed her in 2021, when every call was a fix and every fight was withdrawal. Not the way I needed her in 2023, when losing her felt like dying because I'd made her responsible for keeping me alive.

I love her from abundance now. From a cup that's already full. Not reaching down to her, not pulling up from her, just... beside her. Two people who walked through fire together and learned, separately, how to stop burning.

* * *

It's a story about hunger.

* * *

She asked me once, years ago in the middle of a fight, when we were both raw and bleeding and saying things we couldn't take back: "What do you actually want from me?"

I said something about commitment. About leaving him. About coming to America. About building a life together. The usual litany of demands dressed as desires.

What I should have said. What I would say now, if she asked again:

"I want you to be free. I want your kids to be safe. I want you to finish your degree and get a job and stand on your own two feet and look in the mirror and see someone who got out. I want you to live a life that doesn't need my approval or my rescue or my permission. I want you to be whole."

"And I want to be whole too. Not because of you. Not despite you. Just... whole. On my own. In my own life."

"If we ever meet again . In the same room, in the same country, on the same side of the ocean . I want to meet you as a whole person meeting another whole person. Not two drowning people grabbing onto each other. Two people who can swim. Choosing to swim together."

That's abundance.

* * *

I still talk to her. But I love her like a King now.

Most days.

* * *

I should end here. The resolved version. The King on his throne, full cup, visible mountains, abundance radiating from every paragraph like a self-help book with better prose.

But you read this far. You deserve the last truth.

Last Tuesday, 11:47 PM — our old time — Meera's name lit up my phone. Not a call. Just a photo. Her daughter asleep on her lap, mouth open, one tiny fist gripping Meera's dupatta. Caption: *"She sleeps like you described. Like the world owes her rest."*

I looked at that photo for forty-five minutes. I zoomed in on the daughter's face and searched for my features the way I used to, even though I know — I've known for years — she isn't mine. I went to my contacts. Hovered over Meera's name. Thought about calling. Thought about the hotel room. Thought about her legs on white sheets in a photo she sent when we were strangers.

My thumb sat on that green button for eight seconds. I counted.

Then I put the phone down. Face down. On the counter.

Made myself a cup of chai. Bad chai — too much sugar, not enough cardamom, my mother would be horrified. Drank it standing at the kitchen window, looking at Rainier, which wasn't visible because it was raining, because this is Seattle and the mountain is always there whether you can see it or not.

That's abundance. Not the elimination of hunger. The choice, every single time, to set the phone down anyway.

Some days I pick it back up by midnight.

But last Tuesday, I didn't.

* * *

"The best love stories aren't written. They're remembered."

* * *

* * *

* * *

The best love stories aren't written. They're remembered.

— A. Rathna